to fields of adonis annua

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to fields of adonis annua

by cistus

Summary

Mydei has never had a reason to figure out what, exactly, he feels for Phainon. The nature of their relationship is a mystery that doesn't need to be dissected, and he tells himself that he's fine with the way things are.

But fate, it seems, has other plans.

With the Trial of Nikador underway, he must grapple with an ever-growing problem on his own, one that won't stay hidden for much longer.

curse thy name, mnestia!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

To a child of Castrum Kremnos, the battlefield is where one comes alive. The wanton destruction is sweeter than ambrosia; the bloodied corpses are an encouragement to fight without faltering, for a chance to defy death itself; the screams and cries of the damned and dying are an accompanying melody; and the fear of death warps into a cruel excitement that fuels each strike.

Mydeimos, of course, is no different. From the moment he was old enough to curl his fingers into fists, he has yearned for it. Nine years in the Sea of Souls steeled his desire into something unbreakable to match his undying flesh. Only when fear and pain ceased to have any meaning to him could he prepare himself to walk the path of prophecy.

As he charges back in to strike Nikador's heart once more, he reminds himself of his many trials. Fighting against this shameful creature is not as difficult as anything else he has endured, or so he tells himself. He has long since dissociated himself from reality--if he took a moment to consider his exhaustion, he would immediately collapse.

His body may be undying, but he is not immortal. He needs food, water, and rest. The more desperate for reprieve he becomes, the worse he fares. He has erred many times over the course of this fight, and the weight of his mistakes is not a burden he can shoulder for much longer.

In the Evernight, it is impossible to determine how long this has lasted. Days must've passed, perhaps even weeks. Time has lost all meaning. The world around him is nonsensical--all that matters is his target.

Phainon and the outlander Dan Heng joined him a while ago, but Mydei is not in the state of mind to acknowledge either of them. They exist as blurs in his periphery, easily ignored in favor of his target.

He and Phainon have fought together many times, and such excursions are often enjoyable, as they trade quips and compete to see who can vanquish the most foes. They may even trade blows with each other, just to test each others' steel. This, however, is not such a lighthearted affair. Even if he had the strength to speak, he would not. The slaying of a titan is always a solemn dance, and Nikador is the beating heart of his homeland. Their end means the end of Castrum Kremnos.

But of course, he left this place long ago. He has no need for tears. When the fabric of reality warps around him, and the Trailblazer returns to the battle, he feels only relief, not sadness. When Nikador's perverse form finally turns to ash, he smiles, for he is finally free.

"Easy now, don't move!" Hyacine warns, holding her arm out to stop Mydei from sitting up, which is his immediate reflex upon waking up in an unfamiliar location. Then, his mind catches up to his body, and he realizes that he's at the infirmary.

He has been here many times, but has never found himself laid upon one of the cots. He didn't know he could be injured enough to warrant such treatment, though in this particular instance, it seems plausible.

Has he been here for long? The notion is disquieting, and he hopes he hasn't. He tries to ask, but his throat is so dry that only a pathetic wheeze comes out. Hyacine notices his plight, and props him up enough to allow him to sip some water.

"Was I out for long?" he finally manages to say, though his voice is still gravelly.

"Oh, just around six hours. I expected you to be asleep for at least a few days, but your constitution always surpasses such expectations. Fantastic as always, my friend!"

A pleasing answer. With one concern settled, he has only one other. "And where is Phainon?"

"He left a while ago. He's been by your bedside since he brought you here, but I sent him home, since he hadn't eaten or slept. He wasn't my patient, yet I still feel some responsibility to look out for his well-being."

Mydei scoffs. "Of course. He worries too much."

It's always like this. Whenever he suffers an injury, Phainon insists that he comes here, even though it is entirely unnecessary, and then accompanies him while he is treated, as if there's something to fear. Ridiculous, truly.

"In his defense, your injuries were quite severe this time. Broken bones, internal hemorrhage, skull fractures..."

"And yet, it seems I have made a miraculous recovery, to nobody's surprise."

"That is true, yes... But he's your partner, of course he's going to worry!"

"My partner? In what sense?"

She waves her hand dismissively. "Never mind my choice of words. I think you're close enough for him to worry, no matter the circumstances. It doesn't matter. I've got other patients to tend to, I've already spoken to you for long enough--you need to rest!"

"Can't I be discharged? I believe I'm on the mend."

"I need to give you an exam before that, so no. It'll be another hour at most, I'm certain you can bear to wait for that long."

An annoyance, but he can, indeed, wait. And as he expected, the infirmary door swings open with a gentle chime to herald Phainon's return only a few minutes later.

He appears rather unkempt, with pieces of his armor askew and bags under his eyes. As he makes his way over to the cot, his pauldron slips down his shoulder, and he doesn't bother to fix it.

"You're awake!" he cries, with unbridled joy; his energy does not match his appearance. "I didn't expect to see your eyes open today, or tomorrow, for that matter."

"You seem to think I was in a coma. I was just asleep."

"I've never seen you in such bad shape... I thought you might be, despite Hyacine's reassurance. She tried to rouse you often, but you didn't respond, no matter how insistent she was... And you still don't look well. Can you fault me for my concern?"

There is something in his words that is both familiar and confounding. The depth of Phainon's care for him is unlike anything he has experienced from another being. When confronted with it, he never knows how to respond.

"It's irrational."

Phainon sighs, clearly defeated. Mydei knows he has erred, at the very least, even if he doesn't know why. This isn't an uncommon occurrence. His manner of navigating social situations is *idiosyncratic,* as Aglaea once described--that is the polite way of saying that he is abrasive, tactless, and impossibly stubborn. Even living in Okhema for years hasn't helped improve these issues.

He typically doesn't mind, as he sees no reason to apologize for who he is; however, it bothers him when Phainon is involved. This is one relationship that he actually values, so he'd rather not see it fall into ruin, as so many of his other acquaintances have.

"Never mind." In this instance, Phainon just brushes it off, and Mydei is happy to change the subject. He's quite interested in hearing what occurred after Nikador was felled, seeing as he lost consciousness immediately afterwards. Apparently, it wasn't actually very noteworthy, though the story of the outsider Stelle's trip to the past is quite remarkable.

"Sorry to interrupt, but I'm free to examine you, if you'd like to be discharged?" Hyacine says, as Phainon is in the middle of explaining how

he bravely carried Mydei's unconscious body back to Okhema, which he doesn't find as entertaining.

"Thank the gods," he mutters, while shooting Phainon a dirty look.

Unsurprisingly, he is given a clean bill of health and is discharged within a few minutes. It's a relief to step out of that stuffy clinic--as always, he wishes he hadn't been brought there to recover. He would've been happier elsewhere. Since no variables are able to affect his recovery, his own peace of mind should be the only consideration. Outside of the training grounds and his own desolate flat, he spends most of his time at Phainon's home. In this case, that's where he would've preferred to rest, as it's the place with the most comfortable accommodations.

It's not a large home; while a Chrysos Heir could certainly request a villa if they desired one, Phainon is not that sort of man, and he is perfectly content with this small plot. It is still a lovely house with the usual trappings of luxury, and it is on the outskirts of the city, affording its residents some peace and quiet. Though he'll never admit it, Mydei would say this is his favorite place to stay. There is a sense of security he feels here that he can find nowhere else in Okhema. If he were a more sentimental man, he would say that he thinks of it as his home as well, but he isn't, so he banishes the thought as he steps inside.

"Would you like me to fetch you a meal?" Phainon asks, remaining at the front door in anticipation of his answer.

"Get something plain," Mydei says, and tosses him his coin purse. "I'm going to take a bath, if you don't mind."

"You're always welcome, of course."

There is no therapeutic reason for him to bathe, so he is done quickly. All he must do is rinse off the blood, dirt, and ichor that has dried on his skin--the final traces of his battle with Nikador.

It's strange to think that the prophecy defining his entire life has finally been fulfilled. He still doesn't have much freedom afforded to him, as a more

important prophecy has yet to run its course, but it does take a metaphorical weight off his shoulders. He's not sure if he enjoys this feeling; soon enough, he'll come to terms with it, even if he's currently uncomfortable. If nothing else, he's the adaptable sort.

With his skin cleaned, he turns his attention to his clothes, which are just as dirty. After scrubbing the fabric with the washboard, he hangs them up to dry, and pilfers a chiton from Phainon's dresser to wear in the meantime. He considers polishing his armor as well, but a quick inspection reveals dents and scratches that will have to be repaired. That's a matter for later, after he's dined.

When he steps back into the dining room, Phainon has returned, and has set out a large bowl of stew at the seat across from him. Wordlessly, Mydei begins shoveling it into his mouth. He can't recall the last time he was so hungry. In only a few minutes, he’s polished it all off, and scraped the bowl clean.

"A satisfactory meal," he comments, as he leans back in his chair.

Phainon seems pleased. "Good to hear... You fought against Nikador for five days, I knew you'd need something substantial after that. I just can't believe you lasted for that long, I was certain I'd find you in much more dire straits, yet you were fighting with the same mettle as before."

"You doubt my abilities?" It *is* quite remarkable, indeed, but he'll never turn down the opportunity to back Phainon into a corner.

"Certainly not, but we all have our limits--we're only human. Not even a demigod could fare as well as you did, I'd wager."

"Such blatant flattery is unnecessary."

"Ah, so now I'm being too complimentary? I can't win with you."

Mydei smirks. "I would like you to keep your compliments in the realm of possibility. I am not as strong as a demigod. Regardless, my victory was decreed by prophecy, and I have spent my entire life preparing myself for

the job, so of course I succeeded. Every other battle I have fought did not have that guarantee."

"Well, I'm still impressed," Phainon replies, and offers a beaming smile. He smiles often, but not all of them are as genuine as this one.

He likely wishes to praise him more, but Mydei lacks the patience for words. A tension has built up within him that chatter will not dismiss. No matter how much pride his mind decides to find in his victory, his body always sees it as something to celebrate. The heat of battle has subsided, so his energy must find other ways to express itself.

He stands abruptly. Phainon's scent burns in his nostrils, compelling him to step forward, to place a hand upon his shoulder, to let his intentions make themselves clear. When they first began this arrangement, he'd say what he wanted, but words are no longer needed. Phainon knows that look, and if he wishes to reject this advance, the opportunity is before him.

He does not reject it.

In only a moment, he has Phainon pressed up against the wall. The meeting of their lips is more desperate, the friction of their bodies rougher, and Mydei knows that this time is different.

They are both aware of what will happen in the next few hours. Phainon's hesitance is obvious. Even slaying a god could not dismiss his doubts in himself. He is going to surrender the Coreflame, and it will not be accepted, not without trial. His success is not guaranteed.

Mydei has confidence, of course, but that alone does not equate to victory. If something terrible happens, then this will be their last chance to indulge in the succor of their union. He is determined to make the most of it.

Riling Phainon up is an easy task, he's learned. Perhaps this is due to their biological compatibility as alpha and omega, or perhaps there's something more to it that he doesn't understand. The delicate intricacies of lovemaking are lost on somebody as straightforward as him. He does what works, and does not think of anything beyond that.

He's always been aware that he is a strange omega. There is no seduction in his playbook, no games with cloying scents and words. Such actions are meant to be instinctual to omegas, but they aren't to him.

He certainly doesn't appear to be an omega, and few would assume that he is. His scent is as thick and acrid as the smell of smoke, his rigid form does not seem fit to bear children, and his demeanor is anything but submissive. Still, he is an omega--this world is full of oddities much more profound than a being like him, it really isn't that notable. And even an oddity of an omega can toy with an upright alpha like Phainon.

He breaks their kiss to focus his attention on the side of Phainon's neck to nip at the delicate skin of his scent gland. He receives a strangled moan in response. Phainon barely seems to be keeping it together, but Mydei doesn't stop until he can feel his erection against his thigh.

Indeed, it's that simple, so simple that it almost pisses him off. A warrior shouldn't lose themself so easily, they should maintain their composure even if their instincts demand otherwise. It is a show of strength to resist those carnal urges.

But this pathetic, begging creature Phainon becomes is also quite attractive, and Mydei won't pretend like it doesn't affect him as well. The throbbing arousal in his groin did not come from nowhere.

At this point, he'd typically move things along, but it's been a while since he's been able to enjoy the act of foreplay. The last time he laid with Phainon was two months ago during his heat, and he was not in the state of mind to prolong anything.

He relishes the noises he can get Phainon to produce--such nectarous things. Once he tires of bullying his scent gland, he starts to undress him, wandering mouth sucking welts on the most tantalizing patches of pale skin. Mydei has always enjoyed leaving marks. He wishes Phainon would not hide them under all his clothing; are they not a mark of pride for a job well done in bed? A less proper alpha would flaunt them, certainly.

And gods, are all these layers a hassle. Phainon starts working on his clothes too, trying to undo some buckles and buttons, but Mydei grabs his wrists and pins them back with enough force to bruise. "Have more patience."

He knows he's setting a torturous pace, one that torments him as well. With his experience, he could have all of Phainon's armor removed in a minute. But if he went so quickly, then he wouldn't get to enjoy watching him squirm.

"Gods, My... Mydei, I need..." Phainon pants, desperation and impatience plain to see.

"Use your words, Deliverer. Where's your silver tongue?" he taunts, before grinding his thigh into his crotch, making his hips buck.

Apparently that was more than Phainon could take, because he drags Mydei into the bedroom and throws him onto the bed--a maneuver he only allows to happen in this context. He likes taking charge, but when Phainon is on top of him, he'll cede some control.

And why wouldn't he let Phainon do as he pleases when he rests his head between Mydei's thighs, where he can finally put that silver tongue to good use? Phainon brings him to climax more easily than he himself is able to, so honed is his skill.

Mydei comes twice in quick succession, his legs trembling with over-stimulation by the time his second orgasm has run its course. Without thinking, he'd brought his hand down to hold Phainon's head in place--when he lets go, Phainon pulls back, gasping for air.

Mydei's pleasure always comes first. It's a part of their routine they've never once discussed, it just happened naturally. Once his clit is swollen and his vagina is wet with slick, Phainon readjusts, pressing their bodies together so he's at the proper angle for penetration. The only difference today is his technique, which is much more... *tender* than it's ever been. They both like it quick and rough. Mydei isn't accustomed to these deliberate movements.

The slow drag of Phainon's cock inside of him is unfamiliar. His whispered praise is a new addition to their routine.

But he finds that he likes it, even though he's not exactly sure how it makes him feel.

If this is the last time they lay together, then Phainon has done an excellent job at making it special.

Afterwards, as they lay intertwined in bed, Mydei wonders if there was something more to this--more to this time, and the previous times as well.

In Castrum Kremnos, unions of the flesh are rarely meaningful. Humans have natural urges that sometimes must be satisfied, and so, pent-up soldiers will turn to each other for relief. In the past, he did the same.

But in most parts of Amphoreus, sex is a part of love. And while he was born a child of Castrum Kremnos, that is no longer the life he lives. When he lies with Phainon, he doesn't think of it in the same way as he once did--this is not something so unimportant, is it?

"Mydei, I..." Phainon begins, breaking the comfortable silence, but then immediately falters, and does not speak his mind. This is a frequent occurrence. Despite being the 'perfect' Chrysos heir, he is, in fact, imperfect. Hesitation mars him. On the eve of the most important decision he will make, he is unable to let it go.

A part of Mydei wants to turn over and shake him to force the words out--perhaps it will bring Phainon to his senses. But now, he knows such violence would be a mistake. Whatever lies between them in this moment is delicate, and carelessness will cause it to shatter.

What should he do instead? He doesn't know, hasn't known all this time, and if he doesn't figure it out now, he may never get the chance.

Does Phainon see their relationship as something more? Does *Mydei?*

Godsdamnit all, he still cannot answer. And his frustration in himself warps into frustration with Phainon. "Can you not hesitate for once?"

He knows it is a cruel thing to say, but it is an honest request, one born from selfish concern. The fate of their world is on the line, and yet he wants to help Phainon only so that he can keep him for himself--he does not know what he'd do without him.

"I am trying," Phainon replies, tone unreadable. They're in dangerous territory now. If Mydei weren't so selfish, he'd proceed with careful consideration. Instead, his emotions decide his next words.

"Yet you are unwilling to do what must be done. Stop living in the past, and join us in the present. Your actions can only affect the things around you."

"... Do we have to do this now?"

"If not now, then when? How long until you surrender the Coreflame? How long until you must give up the part of your humanity that clings to your hometown?"

"You seem so certain of how to do this, perhaps you should take the Coreflame," he retorts, and Mydei knows that he's lost his chance. The vulnerability between them is gone.

"I will not. At some point, you *must* become a demigod. Why not now? We'll need your strength for what comes next. But you must be willing to don the mantle, and step up as our leader. I cannot do that for you, and only you can decide what you really live for--the dead or the living."

In an instant, Phainon has clambered out of the bed. "I'm... I'm going to go for a walk, I need to be alone. I'll see you at the Vortex of Genesis."

Mydei resists the urge to follow him--he can't make this situation better. The gods know how hard they've all tried. Now, it really is all in Phainon's hands.

Does Phainon really have the strength to be their savior? Will Amphoreus survive if he does not? Mydei ponders those questions as he watches him leave in silence. He isn't a scholar or priest--he cannot answer, he is forced to wait for fate to reveal itself.

All he can say is that, while fear is a stranger to his kind, he thinks that is the name for the emotion burning in his chest.

Chapter End Notes

> hello everyone how are we feeling about amphoreus so far. i'm feeling crazy. this idea hasn't left me alone since it came to me and i haven't written so quickly in a long time. i'm telling you the second mydei showed up and said one word to phainon i knew what the fuck was up. so here i am.
>
> the other two chapters are like... half done?? i don't know when i'll finish bc my semester is absolutely brutal but nothing will stop me from making the yaoi of my dreams.

abandonment, o fickle fate

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Perhaps it is childish of him, but Mydei resolves that he will not go to the Vortex of Genesis to see Phainon off. He doesn't believe his presence will be welcome, not right after they've fought. The tension between them will certainly be noted by Aglaea, and he'd rather not explain to her the entire timeline of events since they returned from Castrum Kremnos. Some matters are private.

He busies himself at the training ground; it isn't as entertaining as going to the Evernight, but it should satisfy him. He eviscerates a squadron of training dummies with a variety of weapons, from spears to short swords to javelins--he even uses a longbow, in hopes that the struggle with its unfamiliarity will distract him.

Then, once the corpses of straw and fabric litter the sand, he goes to the Vortex of Genesis. The uncertainty of Phainon's fate is simply too much for him to bear. The thought of wasting any more time is more unpleasant than whatever he'll face there.

He is not the sort of person to hope for anything. It is an inescapable emotion, but he finds it more troublesome than helpful, so he's always quick to dismiss it. Still, a part of him hopes, with surprising fervor, that he'll find Phainon triumphant. Mydei will waltz in to find all his worries dispelled, as Phainon stands before him a newly-made demigod, proud bearer of Nikador's Coreflame.

Of course, that is not what he's met with. Instead he finds his allies crowded around the basin, with only Phainon absent. For a moment, that hopeful part of him wonders if the ceremony has not yet begun, and Phainon is just behind schedule.

But the Lance of Fury's constellation is illuminated, indicating only one outcome.

"Still too late, huh..." he sighs, unable to mask the dejection in his tone. This is why he dislikes hope; when it is dashed, it makes failure more difficult to swallow.

"Phainon said you weren't coming," Stelle comments, "I thought it was because you were still recovering... I guess you're better now, huh."

"Of course I've recovered. Did the story of my undying body not sway you? My absence was for another reason, though it seemed increasingly inappropriate. I suppose I should've decided to come earlier, I believe I've missed my chance to bid him good luck."

Castorice nods. "The Coreflame was surrendered, but Lord Phainon's test isn't over yet, unfortunately. The prophecy sent an ambassador. They acknowledged his strength and character, but had doubts concerning the fortitude of his will."

"... I was right to be worried," he mutters, mostly to himself. It is just as he anticipated. If only he could've spoken more eloquently, perhaps he could've avoided this outcome--but there's no point in constructing a perfect fantasy from a past that he cannot change. What's done is done, and now, all they can do is wait.

He considers returning to the training grounds, but since he bothered to come here, he supposes he should try to be personable. He can sulk later. "No matter. I want to formally thank you, outsiders. Were it not for your aid, our campaign against Nikador would have been a hundred times more arduous."

Stelle's eyes widen. "Woah. After all the abuse you hurled my way, I didn't think I'd get a formal thank you! Isn't it nice to be polite?"

Somehow, he finds himself immediately regretting his kindness. "Kremnoans revere strength in battle, but that does not mean we lack all etiquette."

The other outsider, Dan Heng, appears more contemplative. "Mydei, what do you mean when you said you were 'worried'? Did you have reason to anticipate this outcome?"

That question takes him off guard, and he turns to Castorice. "They don't know yet?"

With the camaraderie between the outsiders and Phainon, he expected him to have at least said *something* about himself, but it appears he wasn't comfortable enough to share, or perhaps he just didn't get the opportunity.

"He's always been tormented by his past. I may not be the right person to tell you about him... We have had our disagreements over it, after all. But if you are to continue fighting with him, I believe it is your right to know."

Perhaps sensing his lingering frustration, Castorice takes over, though she gives him a look that indicates she'll be asking him about it later. He curses himself for not controlling his tone.

The moment the outsiders have left the Vortex, she turns to him. "Did you get into another argument earlier? Phainon seemed unhappy when he came here, and didn't mention why you didn't want to come."

"I would not call it an argument, per se..." He isn't keen to admit that it was, in essence, pillow talk. The other Chrysos Heirs must have an inkling that their relationship goes beyond their partnership in battle, but the longer he can go without explaining it, the better. He doesn't want to invite any extra complications into his life.

"Then what would you call it?"

"... I simply urged him to consider his motives for surrendering the Coreflame, as we all have done."

"Yet you angered him to the extent that he did not want you here for the ceremony."

"I pressed him more intently, as I believed it was pertinent to be aggressive. I didn't anticipate this outcome."

"Were you cruel?"

He doesn't like the way she asks that question. They're teetering on the brink of an argument, and he'd rather not argue with her when Aglaea is standing only a few feet away; she's tending to Trinnon, but she's *certainly* listening to their conversation. Aglaea aside, he's not exactly in the mood for this.

"I don't..." he pauses to swallow back the hot saliva gathering under his tongue. "I don't know, I wasn't trying to be, but perhaps I was too harsh. I don't think I made things worse."

"You're quite pale, Lord Mydei," Castorice notes , abruptly changing the subject. He would welcome it, but he doesn't want to draw his own attention to his mounting discomfort. Since he arrived here, he's felt an unfamiliar malaise; he thought ignoring it would make it go away--foolish of him, really. It's only gotten worse. What started as a dull cramping in his stomach has progressed to something else that, while entirely foreign to him, is certainly unpleasant.

What might this malaise be? Before he has the chance to mull it over, he's doubled over and vomited on his boots.

So that is what nausea feels like.

"Oh dear," he hears Aglaea say, though he can barely make her words out past the ringing in his ears. Even after his body has ejected most of his stomach contents, he continues to violently retch, bringing up mouthfuls of sour, stinging bile. And then, once there is truly nothing left, he dry heaves.

He isn't sure how long he stands there, hunched over and gripping his abdomen. When he can finally manage to inhale and exhale evenly without gagging, he rights his posture. Of course, Aglaea and Castorice are beside him.

"Do you feel a bit better now?" Aglaea asks, a concerned note in her usually-even tone.

"I believe so... I did not know such a thing could happen to me."

Mydei has vomited before, but only in battle, when an opponent struck him in the right place with enough force. Immortality does not save one from reflexive shock or internal bleeding. Otherwise, his body is incapable of getting sick, so he should have no reason to vomit.

How odd.

"Would you like for me to fetch Hyacine?"

He frowns, debating what response will save him from another visit. "That is unnecessary. I believe my nausea was the result of stress... I've been a bit worried about Phainon, I suppose."

It is as much of an admission as he's willing to make. Thankfully, it appears to be adequate.

"Ah. Well, I suppose there isn't much any of us can do about that but remain steadfast in our faith. If it is of any comfort to you, I am certain he will return, even if his body is unable to accept the Coreflame. The prophecy's ambassador did not seem to be an unreasonable sort."

"I share her sentiment," Castorice adds, "though I believe your affliction may not be... hmm, never mind. I do not think it is my place to say. I believe you should see Hyacine--not urgently, but you should at some point soon."

Her words are so cryptic that he's stuck on how to reply. Even Aglaea seems confused, a rare occurrence.

"I was just seen by her after the battle with Nikador, I believe I'm in top form."

"Then I may be mistaken. Disregard my advice," she says quickly. She doesn't like being put on the spot, and she's clearly uncomfortable. Mydei

doesn't wish to add to her troubles, so he decides not to ask what she meant. If she made a mistake, there is no reason to berate her.

Aglaea hums, a contemplative hand under her chin. "In that case, I suppose I should take Trinnon to get some rest. Mydei, you should rest as well. Excess stress will not better our odds, and it certainly won't hasten Phainon's return."

More rest--the idea isn't thrilling to him, but she's probably right. A quick nap, and perhaps all his problems will be solved.

A quick nap does *not* solve all his problems, and Castorice's words do not leave his mind.

Over the next few weeks, the feeling of nausea persists, haunting him at nearly every waking hour. He can barely eat--the only foods that don't make him immediately sick are bread and hard tack, and there is no guarantee he won't vomit those up too, so touchy is his stomach.

Certain things are worse. When he attends a victory feast thrown in the outsiders' honor, the wine makes him gag from a single sip, and the mere smell of fish makes him hurry to excuse himself so he can empty his stomach in private.

Is it really stress? He's still worried for Phainon, but at this point, there's no need to get too concerned. Based on what Aglaea said, it seems unlikely that Phainon *won't* return from his trial. The worst case would be him returning defeated, and Mydei already knows what he must do if that occurs.

He does not wish to take Nikador's Coreflame. It is true that his body is the most willing vessel for it, but it could just as easily destroy him. How easy would it be for him to turn into a worse version of his father, a mad king made unimaginably powerful by the boon of a titan's power. The Kremnoans do not deserve to have their future ripped from them, they should not have to follow their crown prince down that terrible path. For all of them, himself included, there should be something more than strife.

But if Phainon is to fail, then he will sacrifice himself. It is the only other option.

No matter how displeasing that prospect is, he hesitates to blame it for his current ailment. There is more to it than just the nausea, after all. *Much* more.

The fatigue is the most mortifying. After only a brief training session, he's winded and trembling, barely able to stand upright. Trying to push himself further has, on multiple occasions, caused him to get light headed to the point of collapse.

But the imbalance in his emotions has caused more difficulties. In the course of minutes, his mood may completely change. His temper is more strained than frayed twine. At the last few meetings he's had with the Council, he's gotten into shouting matches. He nearly lost his temper when haggling with the grocer.

Then, there are the stranger occurrences: the irresistible urge to stay in Phainon's house, soaking in his scent; the potent lust which overtakes him at the most inopportune moments, and takes ages to fade, no matter how he tends to himself; the odd cravings he's had for foods he normally detests.

Still, he tries to dismiss it. He cannot get sick, so this affliction isn't real. It must be a product of his mind. Stress is taking its toll on him. Once Phainon returns, he will be as right as rain.

But after three weeks of ignorance, it is finally time to face the music. In the middle of changing, the sight of himself in the mirror, usually so innocuous, makes his blood run cold.

Something is *different.*

He turns to the side and stares at his figure until he finally comes to terms with it. Undeniably, there is a pronounced roundness to his lower abdomen, and a softening of the muscle there. No matter how he adjusts his pose, or scrubs at his eyes, it remains.

"What the hell," he mutters. He prods at the offending area, finding no give--of course it isn't fat, he's barely been eating as of late, and even his lack of exercise can't bridge the deficit.

How did he not notice this earlier? It didn't come out of nowhere--had he been so intent on denial that he entirely ignored the reality before him? How daft.

I believe you should see Hyacine--not urgently, but you should at some point soon.

Again, those words cross his mind.

Castorice was not mistaken.

Ten minutes later, he steps into Hyacine's infirmary on his own accord. The smell of antiseptic and medicine burns his nose, a hundred times worse than before, and his stomach flips ominously. He grits his teeth. *Not now.*

"I'll be with you in a moment," Hyacine calls. He sits on one of the tiny waiting room chairs, feeling entirely out of place. When Hyacine comes up to the front, her expression indicates that he looks just as strange as he feels.

"Mydei, my friend, I didn't... ahem, where are my manners... Welcome, come right this way!"

The moment they're in the examination room, she starts pulling the typical supplies out of the cabinet, clearly anticipating another wound to clean and stitch shut. "Without Phainon around, I didn't think you'd be coming here, but--"

"I'm not here for an injury."

Suddenly, he has her full attention. "Oh, I apologize. I wasn't aware that you'd have another reason to see me, but anything can happen, I suppose. Is something the matter?"

"I believe I'm pregnant."

He did not expect to ever utter those words. They feel strange coming from his mouth, like they don't belong to him. Fate's hand has guided him down a violent path, slick with the blood of his family and comrades, and it seems unimaginable that it would grant him something so *gentle.*

If Hyacine is surprised, she hides it well. Instead, her cheerful, conversational tone is immediately replaced with her professional demeanor. "You'd like for me to run a blood test to confirm? I can certainly do so, but I'd like to hear your symptoms first, just to rule anything else out."

"I cannot get sick, yet I'm constantly fatigued and nauseous. What could cause those symptoms that is not a disease?" He doesn't want to snap at her, but can't bite back his rudeness in time.

"I see. Allow me to draw some blood, then. We'll proceed from there."

It takes twenty minutes for the results, and he is left alone with his thoughts. With no desire to think about anything of consequence, he stares at a painting of the sea that hangs on the wall. He's never liked the ocean, which he supposes makes sense. Not even time has managed to ease the pain of that memory--it is foundational to his being.

But no, he won't let his mind wander, and he forces himself to stare at the painting until his eyes burn from the lack of blinking. Only when Hyacine returns is his concentration broken.

"You're pregnant."

He expects the confirmation to make him feel something. Shouldn't it? Sadness or happiness or dread or anger--*something* should fill his heart now that the tension is gone.

"I cannot believe I missed this when you were last here! I suppose that's a lesson to me: run blood work as a precaution, even when it seems unnecessary," she continues. Her voice sounds distant, as if she's not standing right in front of him, holding his gaze.

He opens his mouth to respond, but no sound comes out. Another attempt, and he manages a shuddering exhale. He's in shock--why? Kremnoans do not allow their emotions to control them, he's spent his whole life beating that part of him into submission. He shouldn't be frozen by the confirmation of his own suspicions.

Hyacine's demeanor softens, as she must see his turmoil. "If this is unwanted, I will do my best to help you clear the child from your body. To be frank, I'm not sure if it will be possible, not with your constitution, but I have some very potent abortifacients that might work."

All of the battles he's fought since the child's conception--which was certainly during his heat--and all of the injuries he's sustained have insofar not been enough to snuff out its life. He's quite sure that a medication will prove ineffective, even if it comes from a Chrysos Heir.

Regardless, he knows with complete clarity that he doesn't desire that outcome.

He loves Phainon. Gods above, does he love Phainon. He has since the day of their duel, when Mydei tasted defeated for the first time, lying disarmed and prone on the ground, with Phainon's foot planted firmly on his heaving chest. It was as intimate as any proposal. Of course Mydei fell for him. His heart would forever belong to the only man strong enough to take his life.

Perhaps it didn't start then for Phainon, but it *did* at some point, without a doubt. The lingering touches, the soft looks, the overbearing concern, the years of thoughtful words and abundant care that have added together into a declaration in their own right--that was love, wasn't it?

All this time, they've loved each other, and Mydei only realized it once he couldn't express it anymore. What fools they are, to have loved each other so naturally that it happened without either of them noticing. The most important words remain unsaid.

If only they'd said it sooner, this could all have gone differently. Phainon might be beside him--he'd have demanded Mydei come here ages ago, of course. And he'd be overjoyed, wouldn't he?

At first he'd be scared. The wounds of his past would heighten his fear beyond any normal anxiety. But the idea of a child of his own, a family to live for--his joy would overcome the pain eventually. Even the uncertainty of the future would not make him falter once he found his resolve.

On his own, Mydei doesn't think that he's cut out for this kind of thing. But it's easy, so very easy to imagine Phainon here that it's almost like he is, and he can almost believe that he's capable of bringing life into this world.

"I want this."

"You don't have to make up your mind right now, my friend, you can discuss it with the other parent if that's important to you."

He slumps, placing his head in his hands. "... I cannot discuss it with him, Hyacine."

"I didn't want to assume it was him," she says quietly, carefully, as if she's afraid he'll shatter. He's heard her use that voice before on patients with grim prognoses. Perhaps she also uses it on people like him, ones teetering on the brink of the abyss, because Phainon *isn't* here and Mydei was never meant to do this.

A measured inhale and exhale. Another. It's difficult at first, but eventually, he forces himself to calm down.

He was never meant to do anything in his life besides fulfill the prophecy. Beyond its scope, he is his own man. He is not the crown prince Mydeimos with the expectations of thousands upon him, he is Mydei of Okhema, and he can do as he pleases.

"I want this," he repeats, with the same conviction. At the very least, he is certain of his desires, no matter how attainable they may be.

"Thank you for your patronage, lord Mydei! I hope the quality of this garment is to your liking, and if any issues arise, please bring it back. Your satisfaction is paramount."

"Of course."

The package the weaver hands to him is quite weighty, as he expected. Inside is a heavy mantle; when worn around the shoulders, it will obscure the wearer's entire form. Such a cumbersome article of clothing is not his typical style, but it is a necessity if he plans to keep his pregnancy a secret.

For now, just wearing a regular chiton instead of his revealing drape suffices to hide the slight curve of his abdomen, but it will not work for much longer. The child is growing quickly.

Perhaps all of this is more trouble than it's worth, he thinks, as he dons the mantle. Would telling the others of his condition be as difficult as wearing this dreaded thing? It likely wouldn't, but he doesn't want to chance it.

If Phainon were here, he'd know what to do--but damnit, he needs to stop thinking like that. Over the past few years, Mydei has become far too reliant on him for help. It's unbecoming.

Even though he wasn't trained in diplomacy, he's still perfectly capable of handling this matter himself. The mantle will buy him some more time to figure things out, and once he's ready, he'll--

"Hello-ooo? Mydei, are you listening?"

A loud voice interrupts his musings, and he looks down from the rooftop he's sitting upon to see the two outsiders below him. Stelle is waving as she calls his name, and Dan Heng is scowling at her.

"You have my attention now, I suppose... Do you think I look like I want to be bothered?"

"Erm, no, but this is important!"

He sighs, and then leaps down to stand at their level. Hyacine discouraged him from any intense exercise or feats of strength, but a seven meter drop is hardly an issue.

"What is so important? If it isn't a matter of life or death, I'd choose your next words carefully."

Stelle offers him a sheepish grin. "I have an invitation from Tribbie to a special party during the festival of... um, I can't remember..."

"Festival of Skirophoria," Dan Heng supplies, deadpan, and she nods eagerly.

"Yeah! It's in honor of Cerces and Phagousa!"

"I know what the festival of Skirophoria is, do you think I was born yesterday?"

"Well, you're originally from Castrum Kremnos, so I didn't know if you celebrated titans other than Nikador."

"I've lived here for years."

"Whatever, that doesn't matter. If you know so much about the festival, then you know that there's going to be a special gathering at the bathhouse! Tribbie wanted us to invite all our companions. Unfortunately, we still haven't made contact with our friends back on the Astral Express, so we've been going to everyone we know here. You're one of those people!"

"... Alright, I will come. When is it?"

He considers refusing, but he's already been reclusive enough; if he spends too much time away from the others, they'll start asking questions.

"Oh. I didn't think you'd actually accept."

"I would be a fool to reject an invitation extended by our special guests."

"Alright then! It's three weeks from today, you can show up whenever you want during the day--or night, I guess... The way you keep time here is kinda confusing, it's hard to tell what's going on when it's always bright out."

"Fortunately for you, it isn't confusing to me. I will see you at the appointed time."

Only after he has bid them farewell, walked to the market to get a meal he knows he can stomach, and then returned to his flat does he realize his error.

He *just* purchased this mantle to hide his body, and now he's going to go to a bathhouse to strut about in the nude? In three weeks time, his pregnancy will be obvious--Hyacine said he's carrying large.

Swearing under his breath, he unclasps the mantle, and then undoes his chiton, allowing him to turn a critical eye upon his form. His abdomen juts out in a jarring manner, entirely unmistakable when one takes in the rest of his well-muscled body. It's already obvious enough, godsdamnit.

With a weary sigh, he lays back on the bed. Exhaustion, now a familiar feeling, weighs him down. But he already knows sleep will not come to him, he has far too much on his mind.

Almost automatically, his hand comes to rest atop his swollen abdomen. Under his palm, there is life. His child. Phainon's child. What a strange concept.

Despite everything, he feels an impossible fondness. This troublesome babe will certainly grow to be a great warrior. Or, if there comes a time when Amphoreus does not need warriors, they can choose to be what they'd like. A Kremnoan would not wish for their child to be anything else, but Okhema has made him soft.

The people here are too sentimental, and it's rubbing off on him. No matter how much suffering there is in the world, their kindness shines brighter than Kephale's light. The Holy City has opened its doors to the weary masses, accepting as many as it can manage, and extending its reach to protect the rest. While the fate of the world hangs in the balance, the citizens soldier onward, not letting despair overtake them.

He can almost hear his father's voice echoing in his ears, complaining about how weak the warriors outside of Castrum Kremnos have become, and how they'll certainly fall to the Lance of Fury's devastation. Only through strife does strength blossom. There is no strength to be found in the folly of kindness.

It was the last thing he ever uttered before Mydei killed him.

Standing over his corpse, Mydei laughed at the irony as he cried for everything he'd lost. The members of the detachment watched his breakdown like an audience at a play. When he finally pulled himself together, he brushed past them out of the palace doors, head held high, not once turning back to see the devastation he'd wrought.

But that was many, many years ago. That pain is gone, and he doesn't wish to dwell on it any longer. It's already given him a headache. Groaning, he heaves himself back up; if sleep will not come to him, then he'd ought to find something to do, no matter how tired he may be.

So, he goes to Phainon's home.

It's ridiculous how much time he now spends here. He'd be more embarrassed if it didn't bring him so much comfort. He hasn't the strength to berate himself when he feels so miserable.

When he lies upon Phainon's empty bed and buries his nose into the bunched-up sheets to remind himself of his scent, it calms him. Sometimes, he uses this to go to sleep, but other times, he does more shameful things. Today is a weaker day, and so, he does the latter. His hand drifts down, finding his clit already engorged and cunt slicked--it's an excellent distraction.

He's falling apart in minutes, coming while crying Phainon's name, trembling and writhing, flesh burning hot with pleasure. But that won't be enough, he's become insatiable. His own fingers take so much work to satisfy him, and they almost don't suffice.

It reminds him far too much of his heat--all those times he spent it alone.

Before Phainon, he always hesitated to spend it with another. Mydei knows he is a difficult being to handle. He's always been violent during his heats. He bites, claws, and rips. His stamina is endless. He is unimaginably needy and controlling; whatever he desires, he will get.

Only the strongest of warriors could manage to keep up with him back in the detachment. When there was no suitable option available, he locked himself away and made do with his hands, no matter how awful he'd feel.

Phainon must be some sort of masochist for putting up with him. Mydei can only faintly recall what happens during his heats, but in the aftermath, his brutality is obvious. As a silent apology, he'll wipe Phainon's skin clean of dried blood and bandage up his lingering wounds

"I know you can't control it," he said once, after a particularly bad heat. Mydei had nearly managed to shred the collar Phainon had worn around his neck specifically to prevent a mating bite. The thick leather was in tatters, like an animal had been chewing at it.

Mydei had been rather ashamed, but hadn't mentioned it. Phainon, ever-perceptive, had noticed on his own.

"And yet, you always manage to control yourself during your rut. You've never hurt me, even though it would not damage me."

"It's because we're different people," he replied, shrugging. *"Our struggles are unique. We can't help each other sort out everything, but I'm perfectly fine with doing this with you."*

Oh Phainon, sweet and foolish and *perfect* Phainon. Mydei grinds his hips down into the mattress as he comes again, trying to make himself believe that his warm body is beneath him. The memories torment him as much as they comfort him. The familiar scent of this room is more of a taunt when he's returned to his senses.

What if this scent remains his only physical tie to Phainon? Or what if Phainon returns, but only after Mydei has given birth, and must reckon with

everything he's missed out on? Fate is cruel, perhaps to the extent that it would add onto Phainon's immense suffering.

"Please, let me see you soon," he breathes, allowing himself another moment of weakness. If the Fates hear his wish, then it will be worth it.

Chapter End Notes

> ok first off thank you everyone! im always surprised that my insane ramblings get any attention. everything i write is for my target audience (me). i cherish every comment and kudos.
>
> anyway this fic might be longer than 3 chapters. my goal is 3 but i think chapter 3 is gonna be way too long so i'll split it up if that happens. we'll see.

illumination, knowledge bestowed

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"You don't wish to bathe?"

Aglaea's question is innocuous on the surface. But there's more to it, because there always is with her, and it makes Mydei wince.

Of course he's not undressing, but he doesn't have a suitable excuse for *why.* Foolishly, he bet on the chance that nobody would press him, but certainly they'd ask. Who would come to a Skirophoria celebration and not partake in the main festivity?

Even here in the reserved section, the din from the crowded bathhouse below is audible. It seems as if the whole city has come here, more enthusiastic than ever to drink and revel in the wanton atmosphere.

If only Mydei could match their energy. In years past, he did. With enough wine in his system, he would be willing enough to share some stories from his time in the detachment, and regale onlookers with his glorious exploits. But not this time, no. He sulks off to the side, bundled in the mantle, and doesn't imbibe.

"You have to be melting under that big coat. C'mon, the water's nice and cool!"

Stelle is right, he *is* overheating. Even if he doesn't admit to it aloud, the sweat beading on his brow does it for him. The bathhouse isn't particularly warm, but it's humid, and with the mantle trapping his body heat, it's quite unpleasant.

Even Stelle and Dan Heng are more comfortable than him--they were initially apprehensive of the idea of public nudity, as communal bathing is

apparently not a custom of theirs, but they've adapted after the last few months in Okhema. Now, they're lounging in the water without shame.

"I'm not interested," he says vaguely.

Stelle rolls her eyes, unimpressed. "You'll accept my invitation, but won't even *try* to participate. I don't get it."

"It was our invitation, not just yours, and I believe that Mydei can do whatever he's comfortable with," Dan Heng replies.

"Suit yourself. I won't stop you from standing there. Anyway..."

They go back to conversing with each other about their attempts to contact their companions, leaving him alone for the time-being. Aglaea, however, seems to have no intention of letting it drop.

"Is everything alright?" she asks directly, no longer hiding behind her meandering questions.

"... It's fine."

They both know he's lying. The truth is plainly obvious. He's flapping around like a dying fish, pathetic and helpless, unable to save himself from his deficiencies. Self-deprecation does not come naturally to him; perhaps it is the hormones. It's easier to point fingers at things out of his control.

Aglaea opens her mouth to respond, then closes it. Mydei can almost see the gears churning in her head, attempting to come up with the words that will get him to confess.

All of the Chrysos Heirs have been treating him in this strange manner since Nikador's death. They're so careful, as if one misstep will cause him to lash out. And worse yet, Aglaea has only sent him on safe missions within the domain of Kephale's protection; when he protested, she spouted some nonsense excuse about not wanting to endanger his life so soon after Castrum Kremnos.

Endanger his life. Laughable, really, to try that explanation. He's not sure why he let her get away with it; he took it at face value instead of pressing for more.

It bothers him, in retrospect. Do any of them suspect that he's with child, and this is the reason for their behavior? They've already asked questions about the drastic change to his wardrobe, and his response of shrugging it off is wholly inadequate, he's already aware. They're suspicious, yes, but have they deduced the truth?

They likely haven't. Aglaea is the most discerning among them, and she still seems lost, so at the very least, he can take comfort in that fact.

"If something is the matter, I'm happy to lend my aid. Or, if you just want to talk about it, then I'll listen," she says, after a long pause. Perhaps he would appreciate the offer more if she didn't deliver it in the same detached manner as always. But her demeanor is cold despite the facsimile of warmth, and he's not encouraged to share anything at all.

"Well, I don't wish to talk about it, since it's none of your concern. It's nobody's concern but my own."

On this matter, he is steadfast. Aglaea, sensing the futility of her efforts, lays back in the bath and shuts her eyes. He's finally able to return to brooding, though in a worse mood than before.

When an attendant comes around with a tray of ornate goblets, he feels his mood foul even further. He accepts one, knowing he can't pass it up without drawing attention; the Chrysos Heirs know of his passion for good wine.

"Ooh! I didn't know we'd get drinks, this is awesome!" Stelle cries, as she takes a goblet of her own.

"Of course. This is a part of the celebration. The wine represents the cleansing waters of Phagousa, and drinking a cup will wipe away the mistakes of the previous year," Castorice explains, finally speaking up. She's been quiet since her arrival, though she's kept staring at Mydei in a way that makes his skin crawl.

"You have a lot of mistakes to cleanse," Dan Heng mutters, and Stelle elbows him hard enough to make him scowl. Mydei sometimes feels that they are kindred spirits.

"Says the dude in like three situationships at once. I've got my priorities sorted. Don't give me that look, you *know* I'm right."

Castorice cocks her head. "What do you mean?"

"Not important, forget I said anything. Y'know, I think we should mix up this tradition a bit... Let's make a toast! You know what that is, yeah?"

"It isn't traditional, but yes, we do have toasts," Aglaea replies. "In these circumstances, it seems appropriate. Shall we gather 'round?"

That question is mostly directed at Mydei. He wrinkles his nose in distaste, but begrudgingly walks over to the rest of the group. He'll extend this courtesy to their guests. One little sip of wine shouldn't hurt, and that will suffice for the optics. The rest can be disposed of when nobody is looking.

"Hmm, what's a good toast... 'to our good health' is boring," Stelle muses. "Maybe we can... hmm... aha! To our victories to come!"

It's quite the declaration, but there have been worse toasts, he thinks, as he clinks his chalice and then raises it to his lips.

The moment he tastes it, he remembers why he stopped drinking it weeks ago, before he even knew he was pregnant. It's become revolting. An overwhelming sourness assaults his tongue and immediately, his stomach turns as he gags into the cup. The nausea, which has lessened as of late, returns in full force.

Shit. Not now, anytime but now.

He slams the chalice down on the nearest surface out of reflex, trying to get it as far away from him as possible. The clanking noise it makes draws everyone's attention.

"Uh... Mydei? Do you not like alcohol?" Stelle asks, as she peers at him with a creased brow. "Or shit, is it poison?"

"It's not poison, I am..." he forces out, but the other words get stuck in his throat. It's quickly becoming obvious to him that the nausea will not pass on its own, no matter how hard he tries to repress it. He's going to be sick.

With a hand clasped over his mouth, he strides away, ignoring the calls of his name behind him. Each step brings the inevitable closer. He feels like he can't walk straight. Through some miraculous effort, he makes it out of earshot and into a deserted corridor, where he sinks to his knees and vomits into a potted plant.

His stomach doesn't settle until his throat is raw and his eyes sting from exertion. Somehow, the foul tang of bile in his mouth isn't as unpleasant as the wine. His favorite drink has been ruined--yet another sacrifice made for this child.

He hangs his head down, groaning softly. How utterly embarrassing this all has been. At this point, there is no way he can return to the gathering; it seems he'll be heading home early.

How lovely would it be to go rest at Phainon's house, but he doesn't think he can stand making the walk there. He doesn't want to spend another moment in public longer than is necessary. Never has it been such a relief to step into the dim, scarcely-furnished flat he otherwise detests.

He manages to make it into the bedroom before there is a knock at the door. Of course somebody followed him.

"Lord Mydei, please let me in," Castorice's muffled voice calls, after he doesn't respond.

"I'm not accepting visitors right now," he shouts back, not bothering to police the hostility in his tone.

"It is an order from Aglaea, I must check on you. I will break down the door if necessary."

Not wanting to deal with the hassle, he opens the door. Castorice, waiting at the doorstep, immediately takes a few steps back, distancing herself from him.

"Okay, you've checked on me. I'm alive. Now go."

She takes a measured breath, as if preparing herself. "I know the truth."

"What?"

"I know about the babe within you."

"Fuck."

All of the tension leaves his body in an instant, and his knees almost buckle beneath him. So, this is it: the revelation. It feels worse than he imagined it would. With the last of his remaining energy, he stumbles to the small dining room and collapses in one of the chairs.

Castorice follows, taking the seat across from him. She doesn't say anything, she only looks at him expectantly, as if he's meant to say something.

"How long have you known?" he finally decides to ask, voice hoarse.

"I've sensed the abundance of life force within you for months. It was quite weak at first, and I only figured out the source in the Vortex of Genesis when you became ill. But you obviously didn't know, and I did not feel it was appropriate for me to inform you of the news."

"And when did the others find out? Just now?"

"Oh, they still don't know."

"What?"

That should be a relief, but it's more of a shock. It seems impossible. "Were they not paying attention to a thing that happened? I feel it's easy to deduce the reason for my behavior."

"They believe you to be heartbroken over Lord Phainon."

"... Aglaea would assume that, yes, but even the outsiders?"

"Stelle said that you 'made it so painfully obvious' and she felt uncomfortable being with you in Castrum Kremnos because you were 'basically fucking right in'--"

"That's enough, I've heard enough chatter from that insufferable outsider," he grits out. "I didn't think it was that apparent, godsdamnit."

"It wasn't so apparent to me, I only guessed after learning of your pregnancy. I know that isn't much of a comfort, since I am not particularly adept at understanding social interactions. In any case, they do not seem to have suspicions of any other issues ailing you."

He sighs heavily. "That is some comfort, I suppose."

"Why are you so concerned about them finding out?"

"I believe Aglaea would be *displeased*, to put it lightly... I'd rather not take the risk. This is a calculated decision on my part, and I've already thought it through. At least until Phainon returns, I will not inform anybody. That is final."

They both know that his resolve is somewhat flawed in nature, but she nods in affirmation anyway, and offers him the closest thing to a smile that she can muster.

"I understand. If you wish for it to remain a secret, then I shall keep it too, Lord Mydei."

"... Many thanks, Castorice," he mumbles, the gratitude as stilted and awkward as always, though he means it genuinely.

"And if you'd like my aid, I can try to do what you require, though I'm not sure it will be adequate. I believe it is the thought that counts, yes? Loneliness is a terrible pain to bear. That, at least, I hope to ease."

He's poised to brush off her offer, but can't bring himself to refuse, not in these circumstances. Is he lonely? *Yes.* Desperately so. Without Phainon, it's as if a part of him is hollowed out. He was a pure shining light to match the ferocity of Mydei's fire, gentleness juxtaposed with rough edges, a practiced blade against raw, wild power.

Does Phainon feel his absence as profoundly, wherever he may be? Does he look to the sky and imagine them reunited, and whisper his hopes for the Fates to hear?

By the gods, Mydei has become so sickeningly sentimental. This man has ruined him.

"Would you like for me to leave now?" Castorice asks, bringing him out of his reprieve. "I can inform the others that you are in a bad mood, and that you will not be returning to the celebration."

"That will suffice, yes--"

He's interrupted by a deafening crash, so loud that the sound seems to rattle around inside his skull and grate against his brain. In the aftermath, there's pandemonium; metal squeals against metal, people scream, and alarms begin to blare, though he can barely hear it over the ringing in his ears.

Most notable to him, however, is the low rumble that seems to shake the room. It's the chanting of Titankin, distant but overwhelming. He'd recognize it anywhere; it resonates with his very being, commanding his attention. And though he cannot understand the language of titans, he can easily glean the meaning of their cries.

It seems the Titankin, now masterless, still thirst for blood.

In an instant, he's shot to his feet, fists readied and gauntlets materialized. Around him, the air hums with energy; the power of Fury bows to him like a loyal subject, ready to do his bidding.

"The invading force is large, the guards will need our support," he says, already making his way to the door.

Castorice has summoned her scythe, but she hesitates to follow him. "Are you certain you should be placing yourself in danger--"

"The child will be alright."

"But nurturing life within you takes energy, will you have the strength for a difficult battle?"

"I *have* to have the strength, it is my duty."

"... If you're certain."

She doesn't protest anymore, and the two of them rush into the fray side by side.

The Titankin have attempted many, many times, to breach the walls of the Holy City. They are as unrelenting as the tide, no matter how many failures they suffer and how thin their ranks become. Their corpses litter the hills, have piled up in drifts from the sheer number, and yet, they march on.

It is rare that they succeed in making it past the gates, but it *has* happened. On one such occasion, they managed to launch a projectile at the walls, destroying a portion of it and allowing them entry in a place that wasn't well-guarded.

Today, it seems they are trying that approach again.

Mydei leaps through the breach to find a squadron of Titankin just meters away; if he had been a few seconds late, he would've found himself in the midst of disaster. Behind him is a tightly-packed district of civilian homes. Crisis still isn't averted; at any point, they could make it through, and the carnage would be unfathomable.

Castorice went to the front gates, but perhaps she should've come here to lend her aid. As it is, there isn't time for him to plan through his attack. He lunges at the nearest warrior, fist connecting with such force that it's thrown back into its comrades behind it, disintegrating them as well. He then falls

into a roll, dodging a volley of arrows launched at his head. The archers are usually his main priority, but now, it's the praetor shambling forward, greatsword drawn and alight with golden fire.

He effortlessly constructs a greatsword of his own, blood flowing into his palm to crystalize into a blade to block the strike. The force of the praetor's downswing is devastating, enough to fell any ordinary mortal, but Mydei, of course, is unyielding. His opponent staggers back, guard lowered, affording him the opportunity to cleave its head in twain.

Now he can take care of the pesky archers. They shoot another volley; he easily sidesteps, then beheads them each with brutal, forceful swings.

"Good work, lil' De!" Tribbie cheers, and he whips around to find her fluttering at the ruined wall. Her two sisters are lost in prayer beside her, slowly molding the stone back into place.

"How long until the breach is repaired?"

She glances at her sisters, then back at him. "Probably a while, the damage is severe. You'll hold the baddies off until then?"

"Of course," he answers, unable to stop himself from grinning. Another squadron is approaching, and it's time for him to lose himself in the heat of battle.

Oh, how he's missed this, he thinks, as he charges forward. Titankin topple like paper dolls, stone bodies cracking under the might of his fists and blood. They attempt to attack--every swing misses. He's a blur of destruction, alight with the thrill that he's been deprived of for far too long.

This is what he was born to do.

Another praetor charges forward, and he vaults over its blade, causing it to stumble. It's pathetic how it doesn't even try to stop him as he forms a lance to drive straight through its body. Its ichor sprays across his exposed skin, painting him with liquid gold. The rest soaks into the mantle. His smile sharpens. His chest burns with exhilaration.

When he fights, he uses a weapon until he tires of it; boredom has no place on the battlefield. His greatsword is lobbed at the first thing he sees move, and he proceeds forth with the lance, impaling and gutting with glee. Marble punctures as easily as fabric when he's the one attacking. He's an unstoppable force.

Even the fiercest of Kremnoan warriors would not participate in such debauched combat, not like him. They'd have caution, would think before acting to avoid injury. Mydei doesn't think of anything beyond what he can see around him. There's no need for strategy. Any pain he experiences is fuel for the fire within him, coaxing it to grow stronger, to turn into something so terrible that it nearly consumes him, too.

Aglaea once said that he will melt himself down one day. She's probably right, and he doesn't care. If he cared, then he would not be fit for his role in the prophecy. To the undying, all things are temporary.

A wily archer shoots at him while he's removing his lance from his latest target, and the arrow connects, piercing the meat of his shoulder. Finally, an opponent with some wit. He laughs at the pain as he rips it from his flesh. Then, he hurls his lance at the archer's face with pinpoint accuracy, obliterating its skull. A moment later and the wound has sealed itself shut, fibers of muscle weaving back into place.

Wave after wave of Titankin descend upon him, and each one fails to overwhelm him. He cycles through weapons at random, stabbing and bludgeoning and whipping, until he loses the patience for such dignity, and then uses raw bursts of crystalized blood, shredding through everything that dares to approach.

The real challenge has yet to come, though he's readying himself for its arrival: a hulking colossus, slow-moving but deadly, a hundred-odd meters tall and strong enough to destroy anything in its path. Its weak point is at the base of its skull, where the stone is thinnest. He always relishes the struggle of the climb when he has the opportunity to fight this variety of Titankin.

As he makes his way towards it, he finds that he has company: Stelle, approaching from the opposite direction. She's holding her own, of course, but regardless of her skill, it's a troubling sight.

He starts to run, tearing past Titankin quicker than they can react.

"Outsider!" he shouts the moment he's within earshot. "What are you doing?"

"Fighting, of course!" Stelle yells back, before whacking a Titankin in the head with her baseball bat, causing it to collapse in a heap.

He falls into step alongside her. "There is no need to endanger yourself, the Chrysos Heirs have this under control. Get back to the city."

"We're not in any danger right now, Dan Heng is in his Vidyadhara form, he's gonna--" she pauses to cave a warrior's chest in, "--kill everything in sight, no problem. And you guys looked like you *didn't* have everything under control. I mean, you were just off moping about Phainon, yeah?"

"I was not *moping,"* he growls, "and I would rather you not be out here, even if you insist it's fine. We shouldn't take any unnecessary risks."

"Dude, if monsters get into the city we'll be at way more of a risk. I'd rather go do shit than twiddle my thumbs waiting to die."

"Do not call me... ugh, never mind. At the very least, allow me to handle the colossus, and keep your distance from it."

"As long as you let us keep fighting, I guess it's fine... Okay! I'll go bother Dan Heng!"

She prances off, swinging at nearby Titankin with reckless abandon. Once he's satisfied with the distance between them, he turns his attention to the colossus, now looming in his periphery.

It raises a foot, prepared to squash him, and he dashes to its other leg, where he begins the treacherous climb to its neck. The chinks in its armor act as handholds in some places, but in others, he creates picks to jam into the

stone, allowing him to pull himself up with his upper body, his feet braced uselessly against smooth marble.

It is immensely difficult. His muscles scream in protest after only a few minutes. And the colossus, aware of his presence, keeps trying to shake him off, forcing him to pause, clinging desperately to the picks until it stills, lest he get tossed to the ground. He's not keen on making this climb a second time.

Once he's made it up to its hips, there's a ledge big enough for him to stand on, and he pauses for a moment to catch his breath. As he hoped, the colossus now tries to swat at him; it's easy enough to make the jump to its hand.

As quickly as he can manage, he clambers up the forearm. He's in a vulnerable position now, as the colossus has an excellent view of anything he does. Its other hand attempts to grab him, but its fine motor skills are lacking, and it completely misses, granting him a few extra seconds to run. He leaps over the elbow joint to begin the final climb up its bicep. It's steep, and the going is slow. Behind him, he can hear the fingers readjusting--with a final burst of effort, he throws himself forward, just narrowly avoiding its pincer grip.

Finally, he's made it to safety atop the shoulders. Chest heaving from exertion, he stumbles to its neck, eyes trained upward at the base of the skull. Already, he's discarded the picks for a heavy javelin, one suitable for the final blow.

It's a difficult throw to manage. The angle is poor and the wind is blowing hard at this elevation. But Mydei does not miss. His aim is true, and the javelin rams into the weak spot, shattering the rock and causing ichor to cascade out.

The colossus tilts dangerously to the side, nearly causing him to lose his fitting. It's already weak; in less than a minute, it will completely fall apart. He'd rather not be on it when that happens.

So, he jumps.

For any ordinary person, this would be a fatal move. For him, it is an unpleasant landing, but his body distributes the force, and he's back on his feet in an instant, ready to parry a strike from a Titankin, and kick another away. After dispatching them both, he's free to watch the result of his handiwork.

The dying colossus has sunk to its knees, and with a mighty groan, it slumps forward, slamming into the ground and shattering into a thousand pieces. Titankin are crushed by its heavy corpse, others toppled by the shockwave of its fall. Ichor splatters across the battlefield.

"Excellent," he says to himself, before returning to combat. There's no time to rest on his laurels.

But something is wrong.

The Titankin swarm around him, the killer of their mighty colossus--that's not the issue, no, he *should* be able to handle them. This is no different than anything else that's happened in this battle. And yet, his body is no longer responding as he expects. Exhaustion pulls at his limbs, worsening by the minute. He desperately forces himself to continue, but he only manages to fell a few more Titankin before his strikes are too sluggish and weak to even damage them.

He's suddenly on the defensive, gauntlets raised to block, not punch, as he scrambles to pull himself together--to no avail. His legs are trembling. The edges of his vision have vignetted. His skull feels like it's been stuffed with cloth.

But nurturing life within you takes energy, will you have the strength for a difficult battle?

Damnit, why is Castorice always right?

He knows he can't keep press on, not like this, but he's surrounded on all sides, and the only way out is to fight. He whips around, searching for a gap to retreat through. There's nothing. He's trapped, helpless in the face of his enemies.

In the throng of approaching Titankin, an archer raises its longbow. An arrow is notched, and the bowstring is drawn back. He orders his body to move out of the way. It should be easy, so easy to dodge.

But instead, when the arrow flies, it finds its mark in his chest.

Immediately, pain erupts within him as the air is ejected from his lung in a strangled gasp. He *feels* his left lung folding on itself--it's punctured. The arrow slipped through his rib cage and buried itself underneath his heart.

He collapses. His head cracks against the hard ground. His brain slams against the inside of his skull and sparks explode in his vision. It takes all his willpower to not vomit; lying prone as he is, he'd choke.

However painful they may be, an arrow wound and a concussion are trivial injuries. He should be able to get up and continue fighting. He's managed to win battles with most of his guts hanging out of his abdominal cavity, this is nothing.

Come on, get up.

He can't move. Everything is going dark, and he's suddenly cold, despite how rapidly his heart is pounding. It blankets him, urging him to just close his eyes and drift away from it all--his consciousness is a fragile thing, just barely maintained.

It's a familiar sensation, though it's been a very long time since his last *true* death. He is so skilled, and his healing is so rapid that it's rare for his heart to get to a point where it stops.

To be an undying mortal does not mean that he doesn't die--he does. It just comes with a caveat. His soul is so tightly bound to his flesh that it cannot leave at the cessation of his heartbeat. Death attempts to embrace him, but its reach does not extend through the barrier of his skin.

Once his body has regenerated enough to sustain life, his consciousness returns, and he is able to rise again. It isn't a pleasant process--far from it, really--but it's a quick one, no matter how brutally he is maimed.

In these low stakes, he didn't anticipate a death. It's always fine, no more significant than any other injury in its impermanence--but this time is different, isn't it? This time, there's another life he must consider beyond his own. The child within him seems to possess some of his undying qualities, but to what extent, he doesn't know. It is possible that it may not survive a lack of blood flow while his heart attempts to restart itself.

To think that an unimportant battle like *this* could be the thing that kills it--what a twisted sense of humor Fate has. After all this child has weathered, it is only now, after he's learned of its existence, that it dies.

He manages to move, just enough to limply place his hand upon the swell of his abdomen. It is a futile act of protection. Dear gods above, he doesn't want to lose it, and yet, he is powerless to stop the Titankin from marching forth.

He resists unconsciousness with the last bit of energy remaining within him, refusing to let his eyes close; he glares up in defiance at the warrior looming above him. At the very least, he will not cower before his killer. It raises its blade above his heart. He braces himself for the agony of death.

But the pain never comes.

Instead, a great blast of concentrated water vaporizes the Titankin, and all of the others in the vicinity.

Perhaps he is hallucinating, but he swears he sees the outsider Dan Heng hovering above him, head now crowned with a set of horns, commanding the water to tear through the enemy ranks. His power is magnificent; it takes the form of a majestic beast, then shifts into spears to rain down devastation, and then a vortex, crushing stone bodies into heaps of ichor-soaked rumble.

"Go check on Mydei, I've got the rest under control!" he hears Stelle say, voice seeming to come from a thousand miles away.

In an instant, Dan Heng is kneeling beside him. "Mydei, are you conscious?"

He tries to respond, but his breath catches as he inhales, and he begins to cough, blood spilling from his lips. It doesn't seem to end--so much has pooled in his lung and with the arrow still lodged within, the wound is unable to begin healing.

He's bleeding to death internally, he knows. His body can only regenerate his blood so quickly, and with the child sapping his energy, that limit has been reached.

"Don't waste your breath," Dan Heng urges, eyes widening in the most outward display of panic Mydei has seen from him. "I am going to use my magic to heal your wound, it may feel strange. Prepare yourself."

No, he wishes to protest, *just remove the arrow, my body will do the rest.* But the only noise he produces is a groan, thick with the blood caught in his throat.

Dan Heng positions his hands on his chest, and something within Mydei responds, surging to meet Dan Heng's touch. It feels intrusive more than anything else.

"Do you feel that? Focus on it, on that sensation."

For a moment, nothing seems to happen, until Dan Heng murmurs a chant. Mydei seizes from the pure, shining bolt of agony that tears through him. It hurts in a way that he's never experienced before. It's like his blood has turned to magma, burning him from the inside out, in every inch of his body. Involuntarily, he tries to scream, and coughs wetly instead, each one gurgling as blood gushes into his lung. His mouth is coated in the taste of iron.

It's intolerable. He can't do this, he *can't* take it, it's too foreign, too terrible, and his entire world is reduced to it, this pain ripping his insides into pieces. His body contorts--the hurt is inescapable, it only gets worse.

This isn't healing him, it's *killing* him.

"Shit!" Dan Heng recoils suddenly, his composure breaking. Sweat rolls down his face as he gasps for air. "That wasn't... Your body isn't compatible with my abilities. We need an actual doctor from the city who can take care of you."

"No," Mydei finally manages to say, his voice a ragged mess.

"You need medical attention. You'll certainly--no, you're immortal, of course. My apologies. But if you're immortal, why has this injury..."

Dan Heng trails off; after a moment of pause, he draws his spear and makes a quick cut through the fabric of the mantle, allowing him to see the truth that Mydei has concealed for all these weeks.

It clearly wasn't what he expected to find. The severity of his injury is now obvious, but so is his pregnancy. Hesitantly, Dan Heng reaches a hand towards his abdomen, and then, thinking twice, pulls back.

"Stelle, we need to get Mydei to the city. It's urgent."

"Why, isn't he immortal? He'll get better on his own--"

"He's pregnant, and I'm not sure what else to do."

"What? Oh fuck, okay, umm... I'll clear a path, give me a few minutes!"

Dan Heng looks back at him. "I'm going to carry you. Is that alright?"

"... Remove ... arrow..." he heaves, each word a monumental effort. He'll die long before they reach the city if his body isn't able to begin healing.

"Remove the arrow? I can try."

Dan Heng grabs the shaft, clearly uncertain on how to proceed. He's no medic, not in the traditional sense. Whatever ability he tried to use earlier must've been the extent of his healing prowess. He leans in to inspect the wound, a frown tugging at his mouth. Then, without any warning, he yanks hard--the arrowhead slides from Mydei's lung, but catches on the inside of his rib cage, preventing its removal.

Not good.

His flesh, mistakenly believing that it's appropriate to begin healing, rapidly closes around the foreign body. Now instead of piercing his lung, the arrow has become a part of it. He feels the fibers of muscle and tissue snag on the metal--they can't properly seal the tear, and blood continues to drip into his lung with every contraction of his heart.

Dan Heng tries again, but this time, the arrow doesn't budge.

"Stop, it's... healed into my body, Hyacine will... surgically remove it," he pants, finally able to speak again. Some healing is better than nothing.

"Hyacine is a doctor?"

"Yes, she's a Chrysos Heir, she'll know... what to do..."

He tries to stand, but his body is still too weak, and he can't even manage to get to his knees. Dan Heng hefts him up in a bridal carry, the torn remnants of his mantle left on the ground. He doesn't protest the loss. It was foolish of him to believe this was ever something he could hide indefinitely. For better or for worse, the others will find out, and he will weather the consequences.

"... Mydei said to find you, apparently the arrow has healed into his body."

"Oh, hello new friends! Dannie, Grayie, I've heard so much about you! But we'll get properly introduced later. Put him down on this cot, I can take care of him. Do you two have any injuries?"

"Umm... No, we're both unharmed. We're needed on the battlefield, is it alright if we leave?"

"Fret not, your companion is in good hands here. Stay safe!"

Mydei drifts back into consciousness as he's laid down in Hyacine's infirmary. His mind is working sluggishly--seems the concussion hasn't

quite resolved.

"I'm acting as your doctor right now," Hyacine begins, "so I won't berate you, but... I advised you against strenuous activity, and you decided to run into battle with no regard for your safety. You need to take better care of yourself right now, my friend."

"I had to help. How many casualties would there have been without my intervention?" he rasps. A metallic taste still lingers on his tongue.

"It's not about that, it's... Never mind. This arrow has to be cut out."

For him, surgery is not a delicate process. After he's stuffed a rag into his mouth to bite down on, Hyacine begins the procedure, using a scalpel to slice through the freshly-healed tissue around the arrow, and in one swift movement, finally extracts it.

It took a series of long arguments to convince her to disregard standard medical protocol when treating him. In these dire times, supplies are hard to come by, and it would be a waste to use them on somebody who won't reap the benefits. He doesn't need painkillers or blood transfusions. Hyacine doesn't need to waste her valuable time on careful incisions when his body will mend regardless of what she does.

When Phainon would accompany him here in the past, he'd insist on painkillers. With those pleading eyes of his, he'd bend Mydei's resolve with ease, and he'd accept the injection, even though it barely worked. But now, Phainon isn't here, and this pain is borne alone.

Funny how the little things he once found so annoying have become the things he misses so deeply.

In just a few minutes, his wound has completely closed over, the only indication that it was ever there being a faint scar that will inevitably fade within the next day.

No matter what Hyacine tells him, he can't disregard his duties for his own sake. He needs to return to battle; of course, he'll stay away from the front

lines. There is certainly more to be done elsewhere. Guarding the Tribios as they finish their repairs should suffice.

But as he's clambering out of the cot while her back is turned, somebody enters the infirmary, and he stills.

"How many casualties so far?" he hears Aglaea asks.

"Twenty-two, none of them are fatalities."

"Thank the titans you're still in Okhema, I'm certain that there may have been some fatalities without your expertise. How many of the injured are you tending to here?"

"Oh, you flatter me! I have fifteen of the most serious ones, the others I directed to the general hospital. All are in stable condition. One is technically ready for discharge."

"Ready so soon? Is it..."

Footsteps rapidly approach his cot, and Aglaea peers around the curtain, locking eyes with him.

"Mydei."

He can only stand to hold her gaze for a moment before he looks down in shame.

"Lady Aglaea," he mutters, as if the honorific will temper her ire.

It's quiet, too quiet. There is too much to say, and he can't hope to explain himself, not now, not after all that has transpired.

"If I'm not mistaken, you are with child, yes?" Her tone, as always, is unreadable. He nods, knowing that any lie would be meaningless.

"I thought I had detected a change in your scent, but I attributed it to your sadness over Phainon, I didn't consider that you may be afflicted with more than a broken heart. My apologies."

He turns to her again, finding her expression passive, not twisted in anger as he expected. "Why do you apologize?"

"You believed you had a reason to hide this from us, and had to suffer alone."

"Does this not interfere with your plans? I've become a liability." It pains him to say, but it is the truth. His performance on the battlefield was evidence enough.

"You've always been a part of the prophecy. If this was an issue, your fate would not be decreed by its words. I understand your hesitation, but I assure you, I hold no contempt--you are free to do as you wish. Entanglement of the romantic variety between the Chrysos Heirs is not unheard of, and has not caused significant tension in the past."

"Phainon and I are not... in *that* variety of relationship."

Aglaea smiles, a trace hint of mischief within it. "I hold the Coreflame of the romance titan, it has always been obvious to me what you felt for each other, even if you did not admit to it."

"Of course," he sighs. The revelation is not as terrible as he imagined; in fact, it feels as if a great weight has been lifted from his shoulders. What a relief to not have to worry about this nonsense anymore.

"All of this is to say," Aglaea continues, "that you do not have to hide from us any longer. I, and the other Chrysos Heirs, will offer our support. That is my sincere promise. Now, please get some rest. I know you wish to return to combat, but that will be unnecessary. You've already done enough, and the invading force has nearly been defeated. The city guards can handle the remaining Titankin."

"If you're certain."

"I am. The breach has been repaired, and the main gates--"

Again, the door to the infirmary is opened, though this time with so much force that it slams into the wall. Tribbie rockets over, frantic. Mydei's heart sinks to his feet.

"Come to the Vortex of Genesis quickly! Snowy is in trouble!"

Chapter End Notes

> got E1 aglaea yippee!!! i finally earned 36 stars in the stupid MoC with her, fuck that. now to hope i get mydei as easily..
>
> im sure you noticed the chapter count increase. yeah it got too long, i mean this segment is already as long as the rest of the fic lol. final chapter will come out um idk. ive got midterms rn and my profs are being evil.
>
> also note that mydei's combat abilities are based on the very brief description in the "victory in a blink" lightcone. apparently he fights with blood, idk if it's his own or what. i guess we'll find out when his kit is released.
>
> edit: after the um. interesting special program. i've decided to wait to write and post the final chapter until after the update. i care too much about canon compliance. see you in a week!

dearest savior, peace bringer

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There is no word for fear in the Kremonan language.

That does not mean Kremnoans do not know fear, they simply choose not to speak of it. Even Mydei has fears--they are not plentiful in number, but they exist, whether he acknowledges them or not.

Now, his greatest fear is being realized.

The Vortex of Genesis is quiet and empty, except for one soul--and that soul is not Phainon. Trinnon stands at the altar, her hands clenched together against her chest, visibly shaking. Mydei feels sick.

"I can't hear Snowy's voice anymore..." she says, distraught, "something is burning him up inside the trial... His soul is turning to ash."

He didn't want it to come to this, but now, only one choice remains. If it means saving Phainon, he will sacrifice himself in a heartbeat. He can only pray that this sacrifice will not bring down his forsaken people alongside him.

"Get ready, Mydeimos." Aglaea's voice is solemn. They spoke of this fail-safe plan in advance, before Phainon even began the trial, but he hoped, so deeply, that it would not be enacted. She knows of this hope, and perhaps knew it was misguided this entire time.

Phainon was never going to be able to seize Nikador's Coreflame, of course not. It is not for him to bear.

Mydei inhales deeply, trying to banish the tightness in the back of his throat. "I will intervene as promised, and I will bring him to safety. I will do no more."

What a fool he is to hesitate on the edge of this great precipice, and yet, he still lacks the courage to make this leap, no matter how necessary it may be.

Nobody else could ever attempt to preside over the power of strife but Mydeimos. The Coreflame *will* be his, sooner or later. He can run from it now, but it is a chase he is fated to lose. Destiny is breathing down the back of his neck, waiting to crown him as the next king of Kremnos.

For now, Aglaea doesn't press him. "Certainly. This is not the time to make any more demands of you."

"Wait, is it really okay for Mydei to participate in the trial when he's, you know, in such a delicate condition?" Stelle interrupts. He's poised to interject, but Aglaea beats him to it.

"The trial is not a physical thing, it involves only the mind and soul. The babe within Mydei's body will come to no harm, so long as the strength of his will is sound, but if it would settle your worries, you may accompany him in the retrieval mission."

"Their help would be appreciated at this moment--the trial is more challenging than anything I have faced before. There is no telling what we may encounter in a realm born from strife incarnate."

Castorice looks to the outsiders, frowning. "And perhaps that is why they should not accompany you. Our distinguished guests should not risk the safety of their souls, this is not their duty. Allow me to go with you instead."

"No," he replies firmly. "Someone must stay outside in case we also need to be extracted."

"If Phainon's life is on the line, as Nameless, we're poised to do what is necessary, even if it is risky," Dan Heng affirms, and Stelle nods eagerly, while offering a reassuring grin.

"We can handle it, don't worry!"

"Then you two shall join me. We'll locate Phainon, and once he is found, Aglaea's golden thread will guide us to freedom, so long as we are able to withstand Nikador's wrath. If the worst does happen, then Castorice, you will be the one to rescue the outsiders. I can find my own way out."

Of that, he is certain. This trial was made for him, and he can bend the power of fury to his will, enough to escape.

"Now, steel your resolve, and keep close within your heart the memories of valor you possess. Your strength will be the only thing you can rely on, besides me. Follow my lead."

There is no word for fear in the Kremonan language.

But long ago, Mydei had many fears. Each night, gathered around the fire with his closest comrades, he feared that those may be the last hours they were able to spend with each other before the specter of death found them. Perdikkas, Leonnius, Ptolemy, Hephaestion, Peucesta--those five men grew up alongside him into fine warriors, but it was always certain that they would die before him. The thought haunted him just as it infuriated him.

It was weak-minded of him, he knew, and no honorable Kremnoan would have such worries. His friends did not fear death, certainly not--they threw themselves into battle alongside him, matching his bravery without the shield of an undying body. And yet, no matter how many times he told himself that it would not break him, it did.

Each time one fell, he struggled more and more to keep the pain bottled up inside. He was the leader of the detachment, he couldn't grieve for warriors who had, by all accounts, died glorious deaths. But he grieved anyway. Behind closed doors, he wept bitterly over what possessions they could recover from the battlefield. Perdikkas's book of remedies, pages soaked in his own blood; Peucesta's golden lyre, strings snapped; Ptolemy's lance, broken in half; poor Leonnius's death was so brutal they couldn't even find his body, and Mydei had naught but his memories.

It would never be enough. Their lives meant something more than what they left behind. Why should he *not* mourn?

That is when the seeds of doubt were first sown. To see death so intimately, as an untouchable spectator, was to see how pointless it really was. Each death rattle that passed the lips of a friend was a needless sacrifice. Each grave dug in haste was a pointless honor.

Is there really any glory in death?

The day Mydei killed his father, his dear Hephaestion died too, and he finally broke. When he managed to piece himself back together, his heart had crystalized into something hard and unfeeling. *Perhaps there is no glory in death, but there will be no sadness*, he told himself. The crown prince had no need for tears.

He thought he'd well and truly left the past behind him. How strange is it, then, to find himself faced with a man donning the visage of a ghost.

"Tell me your name, brute! Your demise shall be a tale I boast of at the victory feast!"

"My name... is Perdikkas, and I am here... to avenge my people."

The passage of time has dulled his memories, but that face, and that resolute voice, will never leave his mind. He would not deign to forget one of his dearest friends. This man laid with him during his heats to temper them, no matter how violent. Perdikkas was strong yet gentle, loyal to no end, and a beacon of stability they all could rely upon when the world itself seemed to oppose them.

"Do you feel any shame when staying with me in estrus?" he'd asked one night while the others were out hunting. He was polishing his gauntlets, and Perdikkas was brewing up another batch of antibiotics to treat the wounded.

"Why should I?"

"I am the first omega to come from my lineage... Am I not a stain upon Kremnos?" It is a moment of vulnerability that he would look back on with some shame in the coming weeks, but he could no longer act as if his secondary sex did not bother him.

"You did not choose the circumstances of your birth, but you have proven yourself to be the strongest warrior in all the lands, so I don't think it matters. Omega, alpha, or beta--we are all humans with the ability of choice. It is only a hindrance if you allow it to be. In my eyes, you're a great prince. I certainly don't care what may lie between your legs."

"I suppose that is true. I just don't wish to disappoint the detachment if they learn what I am."

"If they're disappointed in you, then they are fools undeserving of a place in your army. We've all seen you fight, Mydei. Even the most close-minded idiot cannot deny your skill."

"... Thank you, Perdikkas," he'd said softly, and then, gone back to working in silence, as if no conversation had transpired.

They never spoke of that matter again, but those words did not leave Mydei's mind. It was with Perdikkas's help that he unlearned the shame he held for his body. That man shaped his perspective on life, and what did Mydei offer in return? Nothing, for he did not have the chance.

Even now, with this ghost before him, Mydei can only watch.

The Okheman warrior threatening Perdikkas laughs, and draws his xiphos closer to his face. "Perdikkas? Even the tragic cries of beasts at the slaughterhouse make prettier noises than your name!"

It takes all of Mydei's strength to hold himself back. How easy it would be to launch himself at this stupid warrior and reduce his body to bloody pulp--but none of this is real. Perdikkas is dead, he never made it to Okhema, he never even made it to stand by him as he slew his father. The trial is just trying to play with him.

"Say whatever you'd like... despicable wretch. It is always better... to die in glory than to return... even in victory. May the Kremnoan spirit always run within me!"

"I see you're eager to die and join your comrades in the hells! Very well then, I shall grant that wish!"

Mydei does not intervene as Perdikkas's throat is slit in one clumsy slash. He does not wince as Perdikkas gurgles, throat filled with blood. He does not move to catch Perdikkas as he falls to the ground.

"Avenge... me..."

Even those words, said with the voice of his friend, do not force him to act. Resolute, he watches the warrior chuckle to himself, before he turns to face them.

"Oh, I see another Kremnoan brute has a death wish--and it's the alpha! The pathetic, cowardly king himself."

The alpha, hilarious. He supposes he looks the part right now, as his body shows no sign of pregnancy, not here in this domain of the spirit. He is unburdened by the weight of a child in his womb. And what a heavy burden it is.

What a disappointment he must have been to his father, what anger must he have felt when he looked upon the face of his newborn son. This *weak male omega* was prophesied to set Castrum Kremnos aflame--how could it be true? The Fates must have been mistaken in their soothsaying.

They were not mistaken, of course. Mydei believes he has proven himself enough. Indeed, secondary sex has no bearing on strength, or lack thereof.

"A true coward would slit the throat of a dying man who cannot even muster the strength to defend themself. Where is your shame, *haikas?"*

The warrior grins cruelly. "You dogs do not deserve honorable deaths. I'll give you what you deserve."

Mydei sneers, readying his fists. When the form of the warrior warps, becoming a crumbling Titankin, he cannot resist the urge to shred its body into dust. In an instant, there is nothing left but rock and crystalized blood spiked in the ground. He hoped it would appease his anger, yet the chanting that echoes in his head does not quiet. His brain feels as if it's pushing out of his skull.

"This insatiable bloodlust... It could only be a product of Nikador's wrath. I've seen this Okheman before. Strife contorted an honorable warrior into a perverse beast."

"It's getting to me too," Stelle mumbles, as she places her hand against her forehead. "It feels like I've had one too many soulglads to drink... ugh. We need to find Dan Heng quick."

"Certainly. It can destroy the wits of even the bravest warriors--it got to Phainon, that's why he lost himself, the fool."

Stelle appraises him for a moment, and then glances to Perdikkas's corpse, still leaking blood on the ruined cobblestones. "You seemed upset earlier, did you know this guy or something?"

"... It's nothing. Let's go."

It is a relief to proceed onward once they reunite with Dan Heng. The sooner they can locate Phainon and leave this place, the better. Resisting the fury surging within him is becoming more difficult by the minute. It is a siren song, drawing him toward their destination: the *true* entrance to the trial.

Nikador themself is the one manipulating this trial. He had his suspicions, but seeing their incarnation standing before him, there is no doubt.

"Ah, Mydeimos. Thou art a keen warrior, indeed. I would expect no less from the blasphemous prince of Castrum Kremnos."

His god's voice rings in his ears, overpowering the sounds of battle around them. Mydei braces himself against it, to no avail. This is not that madness-

drunk beast he fought in his birthplace, no, this is Nikador's true self. To stand before them is akin to standing in front of the sun itself, so intense is the heat of their fury. He fears it may just drive him insane.

"Thou art here for the soul of thy lover, yes?"

He wrinkles his nose in distaste. How is even Nikador aware of their entanglement? Perhaps it is easier to tell here, in this domain of pure thought and emotion, what he harbors for this man.

"I am. Hand over that poor excuse for a swordmaster, and let's be done with this farce."

The incarnation huffs, crossing their arms against their chest. *"I applaud thy courage, but as impressive as it is, I cannot turn a blind eye as thou besmirch the dignity of one who has fallen.*

"He faced the greatest fear in the depths of his heart and fought with exceptional valor, but he eventually succumbed to the brutal onslaught. I whisked him off to the rear battleground, and granted him glory worthy of his tenacity and sacrifice. If thou wish to take him away, thou must prove that thy resolve is a rival to his own."

"Do you think I fear bloodshed? Show me your worst, mad king, and I shall prove myself against it. If I must slay you again, so be it. The Deliverer's return is imminent."

"Commendable! Few forces have such potency as mortal love. Thy noble mother displayed the same spirit with a spear in her hands."

"Do not speak of her," he growls. They're just riling him up, he knows, but he cannot cling to his last bit of sanity any longer. If this is where he loses himself, then it will be acceptable. To bring back Phainon, he must fight with an intensity he has not reached before. Anger may be the kindling he needs to reach his apex.

When his mother died, he was not even a year old--he hasn't a single memory of her. Even so, he mourns her--mourns the life he could have

lived were his father not ruined by selfish visions of divinity. The pain of her loss, and its senseless nature, has always enraged him.

Yes, his father may have been the one to pierce her heart, but something else guided his hand that was not his own resolve.

"Why not? She challenged the dishonorable king to a duel, knowing it was a trap, all to protect thy dignity. Art thou suggesting all her efforts were for naught?"

"It was your fault, you wretched beast! Your madness doomed my entire family before I had even taken my first breath! How dare you speak of her past as if you mourn her loss? There is no need for words, wield your weapon as the incarnation of strife and *fight!"*

Vengeance does not heal wounds, but right now, it is all he desires. He *hates* Nikador with pure, unwavering intensity, and this hatred has become so potent that if he doesn't purge it, it will consume him.

The incarnation only laughs, a cruel, grating sound. *"Thy hatred is as clear as day, Mydeimos. These words must have cut deep. It's become quite obvious why thou chose to kill thy father, yet allowed thy signet to sink to the bottom of the Sea of Souls, refusing the people of Kremnos the glory of their past. This is why thou slew the titan of strife, yet allowed the Coreflame to sit, rejected.*

"Thou art a failure. Thy weakness is in thine essence itself. Shame, such deep shame! A proud legacy has been reduced to the whorish omega!"

"My birth did not destroy this legacy you speak of, it is the legacy itself! Endless strife is an ether that has intoxicated our people for a thousand years, and *you* are the poisoner!"

"If that is what thou believe, then prove thyself! O child abandoned by both fate and honor, show me what thou art capable of, and put out the flames of thine own destiny!"

"... I will rip your chest asunder, titan, just as I did to the former king. If you took everything from me, then I shall take what matters most from you."

"Then ignite the flames of thy fears and step onto the battlefield! Either thou shalt consume me, or I shall reduce thee to ash in the heat of glorious combat! Remember this, Mydeimos: the son of Gorgo will be crowned in blood! The moment I die, thou shalt ascend!"

Mydei snaps.

He roars as he charges toward the nearest Titankin, his fist connecting with its head and shattering it before his rational mind can even process what he's doing. He isn't in control of himself anymore, he is under the bloodlust's behest. The pounding in his skull is now an endless war cry, fragmenting his psyche and overriding every sense of self-preservation.

Each strike of his gauntlets against an enemy brings the slightest bit of relief that is then immediately overpowered by the raging torrent within his soul. All he can do is shed more tainted ichor. He must fight until Nikador's lifeblood has all been drained, and his greatest enemy is finally felled.

Distantly, he hears Stelle and Dan Heng saying something, but it doesn't register. He can only hear his own harsh breathing amidst that infernal chanting. Another Titankin, another, another--it isn't enough. Nothing will satiate him, or quiet that voice.

The warriors endlessly gravitating toward him are unrelenting, no matter how many he kills. Ichor is spilled in such quantities that the ground beneath him shines gold. The fire within him burns brighter, hotter, stronger.

It is unbearable. This is his worst nightmare come true. He is losing his mind, and when he reclaims the Coreflame, there will be nothing left but this unquenchable thirst for wanton violence. He cannot even save himself, there is no chance for him to save his child from this fate.

They do not deserve this, oh gods, they do not deserve the terrible thing he will become. Nobody does. The Kremnoans will follow him through his

madness, just as they follow Nikador, and they will all die. He cannot save them, he cannot resist the temptation of his brutal destiny.

He delivers a devastating uppercut to a Titankin's head, reveling in the cracking of stone just as nausea rises in his throat. Grabbing its limp body, he tosses it into another, and watches, elated and disgusted, as their ichor coats the walls. He swipes his tongue across his lips, tasting what has stained them, and the blood is as sweet and revolting as any nectar.

It is all too much. He *can't* do this, it is too perfect for him and it is so, so wrong--

Behind him, he hears the thud of a foot landing on tile. He whips around, ready to tackle his next foe, but instead, pain lances through his lower abdomen, so sudden that he cannot suppress a groan.

A sword is lodged in his womb, and the one holding it is Phainon.

Mydei awakens with a strangled cry, hands flying to grasp at the swell of his abdomen. Cold sweat coats his body. His heart is beating so quickly that it's making him feel sick.

"The child," he gasps, frantic. The place where he was impaled has healed over, but that does not mean the child has healed, as he still does not know if they are--

"Lord Mydei, it's alright!" somebody shouts, and he looks up to find Castorice staring down at him. Behind her is the familiar ceiling of the Chrysos Heirs's private lounge. It seems he's been laid down on one of the couches against the wall.

"... Oh."

It wasn't real, of course. The child isn't in any danger. He wasn't actually impaled, Phainon only did it to snap him out of his mindless bloodlust. But that revelation does not unburden him of all his concerns.

"Is Phainon back?" he asks, scrambling to his feet so quickly that he nearly knocks his head against Castorice's.

"Yes, he reappeared at the same time you did, and the outsiders followed right behind. All of you were unconscious--the outsiders came to before you did, but Lord Phainon is still out--"

On a nearby bed, he's lying prone atop the sheets, as pale as a specter. Aglaea is seated beside him, two fingers pressed against the pulse point of his neck. His hackles raise at the intermixing of her scent with Phainon's--foolish, really, to be bothered by another alpha's scent, but his pregnancy has made his instincts harder to ignore.

"How is he?" he asks, as he approaches the bedside. Phainon's face is ashen, and he cannot resist the urge to reach out and card his fingers through his hair, though he does resist the urge to bury his face in the crook of his neck.

He looks terribly unwell. Even asleep, his face is twisted in discomfort. His breathing is uneven, almost frantic. Mydei pulls back, frowning.

"Ah, you're awake," Aglaea greets. "Lord Phainon seems to be fine, at least physically, and Trinnon reports that his soul is whole and hale. With ample rest for both body and mind, he'll be up in no time."

Mydei exhales a breath he didn't realize he was holding. "Good."

"Based on what the outsiders told us, it seems the trial forces one to face the greatest fear in the depths of their heart... So, Lord Phainon must have had to relive his past, when he watched his homeland be devoured by the Black Tide," Castorice says, voice tinged with sadness.

"In all likelihood, he did. I saw images from my own past, but warped into something even more dreadful. I can only imagine what he saw. The Black Tide is an evil incomparable to any other."

"Is the Black Tide really so scary? Dan Heng and I have heard you all talk about it so much, but we don't actually know what it is," Stelle says from her place on another couch, seated beside Dan Heng.

Aglaea is quick to explain, as always. "It is a source of madness in this world, an unspeakable... *thing* that is as relentless as any plague. It appeared alongside the three titans of trickery. Nobody knows where it came from, all we know is that it is steadily encroaching upon Amphoreus, surrounding this tranquil city much like the tides--that is why it got its name.

"Those who succumb to it lose all wit and humanity, becoming nothing more than monstrous husks. No creature is immune, even gods and titans cannot escape its clutches."

"Though Nikador is an embodiment of calamity, they are meant to bear the responsibility of fending it off," Castorice adds, "which is perhaps why Lord Phainon threw himself into the Trial of Nikador so readily."

"But now, we must look for other methods of reigniting the flames of strife," Aglaea concludes, before casting her gaze to Mydei. "If it were as simple as emerging triumphant on the battlefield, the Kremnoans would have already been fighting against the Black Tide in Nikador's stead. Of course, it is not that simple. One must bear the heavy crown of divinity."

Mydei glowers at her, now lacking the patience for niceties. "It is a decision I cannot make in haste, do not lecture me. There is still more I must do."

"I simply mean to encourage you to consider your next steps--"

"I'm leaving."

Nobody tries to stop him. If they did, he thinks he'd try to strangle them.

He makes his way across the palace, without a clear destination in mind. As he wanders, he is acutely aware of the stares he's getting--he's no longer making any efforts to hide his pregnancy, and having donned his regular garb once more, it is glaringly obvious. He ignores them all. He has much more important worries than his public image.

Whatever the people think of him has no bearing on what he does next. It's not like they've ever *loved* him, they've simply tolerated his presence. As

for the other Kremnoans, they look upon them with much less respect. He is a Chrysos Heir, while they are just brutes hungry for their next battle.

After all these years, that sentiment has not changed much. He thinks he's begun to understand why.

Eventually, he finds himself leaned against the railing of an observation point, looking over the sprawling cityscape of Okhema. It has become his home now, much more familiar to him than his birthplace, which he has only seen in ruin. Whatever beauty it once held is gone. Regret is all that remains.

Just as he detests Nikador, he detests Castrum Kremnos. That city is a temple for a merciless titan, one who has groomed their people into believing death is something to be cherished more than life. The gilded marble is a facade for a deep, terrible sickness. His people think of it as their home, unwilling to accept that there is something better, *kinder* for them in this world.

A stray palm comes to rest upon his swollen abdomen as he sighs to himself. He wishes his child could grow up here, in these joyous and vibrant streets, surrounded by other children who dream of life, not its end.

But that wish is dead. The child will go where he goes, and he doesn't think he has much time left here. A plan is beginning to take shape in his mind--it is not a pleasant one, but it may be the thing to save his people, even if he himself is lost to strife.

Before that, though, he requires a confirmation.

"... I know you've been following me, Tribbie," he mutters, and she squeaks in fear behind him.

"Sorry! **We** just had to ask you something! But **we** know you're worried about Snowy, so it can wait--"

"I'm not worried."

"Oh... **we** assumed you were, since **we** know he's very special to you."

"... My apologies, that was rude. But I'm not worried about him, he will certainly pull through. That fool has endured worse."

Mydei does not know the extent of his suffering, but it is much deeper than a simple trial. Failure is one thing. Loss is another.

She giggles. "It's alright, being straightforward suits you better. Congratulations, by the way! **We**'re all excited to meet your baby! **We**'ll make you a cute gift to give them, and **we** can plan a baby shower for you too! If you need advice, **we** know a lot about children!"

"Err, that will be unnecessary... Thank you, regardless."

"Aww, okay. Can **we** ask you about the trial, if you're up for it? **We** wanted to know what you saw."

"I saw something that terrifies me. It's quite ironic, I'm aware, but that is the truth."

"Do you think you stand a chance against it?"

As he expected, this is why she followed him. He takes a deep breath, and tamps down his rage. He will not raise his voice at Tribbie, not like he did with Aglaea. She was right anyway, it was foolish of him to run.

Truly, it is time for this farce to end, and for him to stop dragging his feet.

"I see why you're questioning me now. This is just the next step in your plan, is it not?"

She cocks her head, feigning innocence. "What plan?"

"Phainon was always going to fail, and I was always going to be the one to reclaim Nikador's Coreflame. You knew all along, even though you didn't attempt to stop him. All you wished to do was buy me time to strengthen my resolve."

"Looks like you know everything, huh..."

"I'm not upset, don't make that face. The Flamechase journey is no game, I am fully aware, and I do not hold it against you for plotting. Somebody needs to reclaim the Coreflame of Strife urgently, or we may lose Oronyx and Cerces to the Black Tide. You've given me all the time you could, and now, it is time for me to meet my destiny."

"So, are you ready?"

"No. I do not hold the key to completing the trial. If I wish to conquer my fear, I must speak with my fellow Kremnoans. It won't take long, I promise."

"... Your people wish for you to become king, right? You're their hero, the only thing that's kept their spirits up since they had to flee to Okhema. Once you ascend, they'll happily follow you, and do whatever you wish."

"Perhaps I was once their hero, but... Lady Tribios, therein lies my greatest fear."

Without another word, he turns his back to her, and walks back to the palace. He doesn't have any more time to waste, there is one person with whom he wishes to converse above all others.

"Krateros, I'd like a word."

He finds his old master near the Verax Leo in the bathhouse, looking off into the verdant gardens grown wild under the eternal sunlight. Even after so many years, Krateros is as fit as ever, though one of his eyes is slowly losing its function; Okhema's healers tried to slow its decline after a grievous injury, but the damage was already done. It is milky white now, the edges of the iris blending into the sclera.

"Ah, Mydeimos. I will provide my counsel as... always..."

When Krateros turns to face Mydei properly, he trails off, stunned. His gaze is fixed on his midsection, and his mouth hangs open.

"Do not gawk at me. Have you never seen an expectant male omega?"

He quickly schools his expression. "Certainly not, I just... I didn't think you'd find somebody to court, much less settle down with. Nobody else could hope to match your prowess and be worthy of your hand in marriage, or so I thought."

The babe was an accident, but Krateros does not need to know of this fact. Whether it was his intention or not, the truth of the matter is the same. Phainon is the only one he will lay with now.

"There is one whose skill is equal to mine."

"Indeed? If so, I'm glad to see you've found happiness in some form. Your mother would be overjoyed, I can only imagine how she'd feel. Ah, the festivities we'd have for the next heir of Kremnos... They would be grander than the ones we had when she was carrying you. How many gifts there would be for you and the young babe, and how lavish they would be!"

"... I do not have time to discuss this right now."

"Sorry, it's too easy to get lost in the past. How shall I advise you?"

"I wish to discuss the future of the Kremnoans."

"Hmm, how interesting, I thought you might come to ask about this. I heard the Coreflame was returned, and yet, you still have not reclaimed its power. Some even say that you plan to give it up. Is this true?"

"Those rumors are not entirely groundless."

"You mean to say that you've entertained the thought of giving up the throne, and forsaking your people?"

There is a hint of anger is Krateros's voice, just as he anticipated. Mydei chooses his next words carefully. "The divine power is not equivalent to the throne. Our people need not follow the path of strife--"

"Enough with the word games!" he barks suddenly. "You, of all people, should understand the plight of our people! Think of the detachment, and all the people who left their homes to follow you, believing in your future! Only memories of the past have kept us alive all these years!"

"There is more to life--"

"Don't be ridiculous! Perhaps these foolish Okhemans believe that strife is unimportant, but it is our lifeblood. If the people lose you... Imagine the disgrace it would bring upon your departed mother, Mydeimos. She died for you, to end Eurypon's schemes, to restore the glory of Castrum Kremnos! Now, the child you carry within you is a gift--a new heir to continue our legacy!"

"... Who is responsible for my father's death, Krateros?"

"Do you think I've gone senile and forgotten that glorious moment? You drove the spear into his heart with your own two hands."

"That was merely the final outcome. How do you not yet see it? It is strife that brought us to that point, strife that killed my mother, strife that drove the Kremnoans from their home. Our principle tenant 'valorous death before triumphant return'... *why?* Why do we place death on a pedestal? Why do we not yearn for life with the same fervor?"

Krateros scoffs, contempt etched into the hard lines of his face. "Gorgo, the great founder of Castrum Kremnos, was your mother's namesake. I swore to her that I'd guard your crown with my life... I never thought you'd be the first to turn your back on the Kremnoan spirit. It's in your blood, and nourishes the child within you."

"That is what you believe, but I'm not sure if it's the truth," Mydei spits back, a protective hand guarding the place where his child rests. "I do not wish for their fate to be determined by a dead god. Nothing is set in stone."

"Do not be naive. The throne has always been waiting for a worthy king such as yourself. Do not fault me for withholding my loyalty if you refuse it, and doom us all."

"It appears you are not yet ready to discuss the future of our people, then."

"Go down the path you deem to be correct. I know I cannot change your mind once it is set. Just don't renounce our traditions, and know that the people of Kremnos will always be bound to strife. There are things in this world that you cannot hope to alter."

"Tradition does not matter in this era of destruction. If I must burn it to the ground, then I shall."

"My young lord, bear in mind that you should not reveal your vulnerabilities to anyone. If one has the strength to dominate, they should. Do not stoop to frolicking with your prey."

"... You sound like my father. If you only see strength in dominion, then you are no better than him."

"Do not compare me to--"

"Listen to yourself speak!" he roars, voice shaking with rage. "Do you not hear the cruelty in your words? Do you think you're better than him when you only care about the same damn things? *No!* You have had the chance to redefine yourself, and yet you've decided to remain a coward! *Get out of my sight!"*

Since he met Krateros in the detachment, Mydei has always looked up to him as a source of wisdom and sound counsel. He trained him in the handling of all varieties of weapons, and as he began to realize the power gifted to him by his heritage, Krateros taught him how to control it. In some ways, he was a parent. Orphaned and alone, his master was the one to transform him from a traumatized child, fresh from seven years of agony in the Sea of Souls, to a capable warrior.

It is a terrible shame to burn another bridge, but if he is to defy fate, then he will do it. Becoming a demigod requires unbearable sacrifice. Very few have the strength, and that is why Aglaea hand-picked him for his role.

And yet, he still does not know what, exactly, he should do. Only one other person may provide him with the clarity he needs, and that person is currently unconscious.

When Phainon wakes, they will have much to discuss. He can only hope that it will not break them both.

Chapter End Notes

> once again the chapter count increased. amphoreus story quest you are too goddamn interesting. my favorite part of the 3.1 quest was when the screen went black and we listened to mydei and phainon panting and grunting. my least favorite part was the entire second half when i was emotionally fucking destroyed forever.
>
> anyway next chapter should be the last chapter..?? i actually cannot promise that, i'm not sure how to transition from having phaidei fuck nasty to them suffering immensely. if my writing ability fails me then i'll split it up lol (this fic was not supposed to be this long damn you hoyoverse).
>
> i don't know if i have the emotional strength for the ending but. i guess i'll channel my anguish into this. FUCK!!!

speak not of farewells

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Three days later, at the beginning of action hour, Phainon wakes.

Mydei is lounging on an armchair dragged next to his bedside, holding a book that he isn't giving much attention, when he hears Phainon let out a low groan. Immediately, he jumps into action, grabbing a blanket to obscure his form and then hurrying to sit on the mattress beside him.

Phainon squints against the light streaming in through the window, expression twisted in discomfort, eyes darting around uncertainly. He reminds Mydei of a cornered animal, one desperate for escape.

"Welcome back to the world of the living," Mydei says, hoping the sound of a familiar voice will bring him to his senses. It seems to work. Phainon relaxes against the bed, tension vanishing.

"What... what happened?" he asks in a ragged voice. "Did I fail?"

"Yes. I had to remove you from the trial, or you were going to die."

"... I'm sorry."

Mydei opens his mouth, and then shuts it, unsure of what to say. Obviously, comfort has never been his forte.

"It's alright," he finally offers, knowing it is wholly inadequate. No words could hope to explain what he has gone through.

Phainon smiles weakly up at him. "You're not too upset?"

"No, why should I be? You did your very best to defy fate for my sake, and I thank you for your efforts."

"I suppose I did try... It didn't mean much in the end. All I did was waste some time. You're going to take the Coreflame in my stead, right?"

"I will, yes," he says haltingly. "We can discuss that later, you should focus on regaining your strength, not the Flamechase. How do you feel?"

"Fine, I think. You went into the trial, you know how it felt... You know what sorts of things one must face. It felt like I was in there for an eternity, lost in rage and grief, trying again and again to banish my greatest foe, but not having the strength. I forgot everything but the feeling of my greatsword in my hands, and my hatred."

He pauses for a moment, looking off into the distance with a thousand-yard stare. Whatever is going through his mind, he seems to dismiss it with a shake of his head, and continues.

"It's strange to be out of it, and to see the world as it is once more. I'm not sure how I can go back to living my ordinary life after experiencing what I did."

Mydei huffs. "It was only six weeks that you were there, you'll readjust soon enough. I cannot deny your tenacity."

"What a flatterer," Phainon replies, smile becoming a bit more genuine. "I'm glad you're not mad at me."

"You frustrate me to no end, but I have never been mad at you, Deliverer. You are not deserving of my anger. There are many things in this world that are worse than your occasional foolishness."

"I'll try to be easier to put up with, but I can't promise anything."

"... You do not have to change yourself for my sake, you are perfect as you are."

Mydei cringes at his own words the moment they've left his mouth. He's being ridiculous.

"I'll leave you to rest--"

"Wait, Mydei... Can we talk? Not about the Flamechase, but about... about us."

"We can, if you so desire."

Suddenly, the air in the lounge feels too stuffy. Mydei has had weeks to think of what to say in this moment when it inevitably arrived, and yet, he's only drawn blanks.

He's not ready--but it's not as if it matters. The world won't wait for him.

"When I was in the trial, I kept thinking about you, in the brief moments of lucidity I'd have. I wasn't sure if I'd make it, and I just... I was consumed with regret. I feared I'd missed my chance to tell you all I wished to tell you, that my hesitance had robbed me of yet another opportunity. I couldn't bear it. And now that I'm afforded the opportunity, I won't squander it."

Mydei's heart feels as if it has leapt up and lodged itself within his throat. "What do you mean?"

He knows exactly what Phainon will say next, has known. Still, nothing can prepare him for the way that his expression softens, becoming something so raw, so vulnerable, that Mydei is paralyzed before him.

Dear gods, it's terrifying.

"I love you, Mydei."

The words are too gentle. Any thoughts tearing through Mydei's mind halt in their tracks, and all he can manage is a strangled question.

"... Why?"

"Why not? You showed me that life is for the living, and that I am more than the past I cannot change. The things I failed to protect, the people... they wouldn't want me to live like I did before, tormented by their memory. They would want me to use their memory as fuel for righteous anger, so I could fight for the lives of all the others endangered by the Black Tide.

"But until you, I didn't have the strength to realize any of that. I didn't understand you for so long--how could you continue to live in spite of all you had lost? Your home, your family, your childhood... *everything* is gone. And yet, you persevere. I understand now.

"So, I love you. Of course I love you, I was doomed from the moment we first met. If you don't feel the same, it's alright. I know I'm weak--I couldn't even complete the trial, despite everything. Perhaps I am unworthy of your affections. But regardless, I knew I had to tell you. Make of it what you will."

Mydei cannot respond anymore. There is nothing left to say. So, he grasps Phainon's chin and leans in to kiss him instead.

It is soft at first, nothing like the kisses they've shared in the past that were so heated with passion. Phainon melts into it. The languid press of their lips is unfamiliar, but it feels right. It's as much of a confession as Phainon's fancy words--Mydei has always been one to let his actions speak for themselves.

When neither of them attempts to break away, Mydei moves in closer, carefully straddling Phainon's hips. He can be gentle, he thinks. A Kremnoan would not be, but he can learn, they can all learn, he hopes.

The blanket draped around his shoulders slips, and Phainon's hands glide down his bare skin, slow and deliberate, as if committing it all to memory. Mydei shivers under the feather-light touch. He feels faint from the lack of oxygen, and breaks the kiss momentarily, chest heaving.

"We're in the Chrysos Heirs' lounge, somebody could walk in," he says, voice low, as he tries to cling to reason.

"To hell with that, I don't care," Phainon growls, and then slots their lips together again, as he reaches for Mydei's right breast. The flesh there is so tender, just his fingertips against it is almost too much. An embarrasing noise is wrenched from him, something close to a whine, that's muffled against Phainon's mouth.

Already, arousal pulses in Mydei's core, desperate for more. It is a struggle to restrain himself. This is not his time to lead, Phainon must set the pace. If all he wishes to do is touch, then that is what they shall do, no matter how much Mydei's body begs to continue. These wandering hands will be enough.

But Phainon's hands still when they reach his abdomen. One palm lays flat against the gentle swell, applying a trace amount of pressure, *examining.*

For a moment, it feels comforting. An instinctual need is settled somewhere deep in the back of his brain stem.

And then, his logical mind catches up with him.

Shit.

He jerks back suddenly, as if creating distance will undo what just happened. It's too late, he knows. Phainon, wide-eyed, stares at the place where his hand just rested. By touch alone, perhaps it could be mistaken for something else, but the unwavering curve of his lower abdomen, unobscured by clothing, could really only be one thing.

"Mydei, what... what is this?"

"It's... I..."

His mouth is dry, an attempt at an excuse withering in his throat.

This isn't how he wanted to tell Phainon. He's not sure what he would've done instead, but at the very least, he didn't want it to be so sudden. Phainon only just returned. His mind is still stuck on the events of the trial, and his exhaustion has not yet faded. Now isn't the right time.

But perhaps Mydei should stop running from the inevitable. Perhaps now is as good a time as any to tell him, and unburden himself.

"You left something behind after my last heat," he mutters hoarsely, after an unbearable pause. It is a wonder his voice doesn't shake. "Something more than memory."

Phainon's expression is entirely unreadable as his eyes remain trained on physical evidence of their union, the thing that grows beneath his skin. He reaches out again to touch, and Mydei does not recoil this time. The warmth of his hand seems to burn.

Silence settles between them. Mydei can only bear it for a minute before he speaks again, even quieter than before.

"I am with child."

In a heartbeat, Phainon surges upright, wrapping his arms loosely around him, pulling them together in an akward phantomime of a hug. Against his chest, Mydei feels his shuddering inhale.

"Fuck," he breathes, almost inaudibly. Mydei does not know what else to say, and simply allows Phainon to hold him.

"... I'm sorry. You were... were carrying a child--our child--and I wasn't there for you. Did you know?"

"Before you left? No, I did not. I only realized when my body began to swell... I could deny it no longer."

"Gods, I'm sorry. I'm so sorry," Phainon mumbles. "I can't believe you were pregnant and I just left you alone."

"Why must you apologize? I am the one who refused the Coreflame and sent you in my stead. Your absence was my doing."

"It's nobody's fault, it just... *hurts.* Hurts to know that I could've been there, but I wasn't. I'm apologizing because the Fates are unkind, and somebody owes you a sort of kindness."

He thinks Phainon is the only kindness he has left in this world.

"You're here now, that is enough."

"But that doesn't mean the memory isn't still painful. Weren't you afraid?"

He laughs without humor. "What do you think?

Regardless of what he might say next, Phainon can discern the truth. Since they first met, he's always been an expert in decoding Mydei's stilted displays of emotion.

"Whatever pain I may have will fade with time," he continues, "and I will manage. Even now, I do not know exactly what to do. To carry and raise a child... Such a task is unfamiliar to us both. All I know is that I want to do this with you, if you are willing."

He knows he should not ask that; shame burns within him as he speaks. There is very little time left before his departure, and it is cruel to make Phainon think he will stay. His wants are unimportant, his duty is paramount.

But he says it regardless, because he is selfish.

"Of course I am. I can't pretend to know what to do, you're right. But we're a good team. Raising a child with you would..." his voice breaks. "It would mean the world to me. Gods, Mydei, I love you so much."

"Despite everything?"

"Because of it."

Mydei lets out a measured exhale. "I thought you'd be upset. I decided to carry this pregnancy to term without any regard for what it might do to your precious reputation. Unmated, unmarried--just an accident we were too foolish to avoid making."

"I don't care about that. Your happiness is more important than something so superfluous. If it truly bothers the people of Okhema, then that isn't my problem, it's their own. I do not need to bend to their disdain. I will fight for their safety regardless of how they feel."

"You would endure that thankless job for my sake?"

"I would endure *anything* for your sake, Mydeimos."

Mydei kisses him again, open-mouthed, more desperate than before. Their bodies press closer, flesh meeting flesh. Any prior restraint starts to slip away.

"Damn your silver tongue," he mumbles, voice thin, when he pauses to breathe. He leans in to the side of Phainon's neck, pressing his nose against his scent gland to ground himself.

"It's the truth," Phainon replies, before adjusting his position, slipping his thigh against Mydei's crotch, allowing him to get friction. It's just what he wants. Finally, he doesn't have to pathetically hump his mattress while imagining his fingers are something else. He has Phainon again, pliant and willing and *real.*

For a few minutes, he is content. But soon, the stimulation through layers of fabric isn't inadequate for his hormone-driven desire. He's so slicked that it's coating his inner thighs, and everything aches. More, he *needs* more. If the bulge in Phainon's pants is any indication, he does as well.

If Mydei were slightly more impatient, he'd rip his clothes right off. He has enough mind left to undo his pants in the proper manner. Phainon takes longer to remove his own, longer than Mydei would like. But soon enough, he's freed his cock from his briefs. He's already hard, standing proudly at attention.

Mydei resists for a moment. "Are you certain you're fit enough for sex?"

"Yes. Exhaustion cannot keep me from you, nothing can. But perhaps you can do most of the work?"

"Hmm... That's a satisfactory arrangement."

Mydei pushes Phainon down, mounts him, braces a hand against his chest for balance, and in one quick movement, takes his entire length.

"Holy--s-shit," Phainon gasps, that silver tongue immediately stuttering, "oh my g-gods, Mydei, you..."

"You said you'd do anything for me," he grunts, as he begins rocking his hips. "I need you to take responsibility for this. Do you know what pregnancy has done to me? Do you know how feverently my body aches for your touch, how insatiable I am?"

His response is a choked whimper.

"You must fully satisfy me now, D-Deliverer."

His words falter when he slightly increases his pace, and his cunt tenses around Phainon's cock. It feels better than he recalled; all his memories, so many of them clouded by heat, could not capture this fullness.

Phainon twists his neck, pressing his cheek into the pillow behind him, groaning. *So beautiful,* Mydei thinks. His ectasy is plain to see. It must be overwhelming, but so long as Mydei receives no indication that he is in pain, he'll continue. The burning heat in his core is tempered just as it is stoked, and he is lost in the pursuit of climax.

He's already so close--for weeks, he has been impossibly pent-up. Blindly, he reaches down for his clit, and almost comes from the slightest contact. It is a monumental task to pull back, so great is the temptation for release.

Later, perhaps, he'll have the patience to draw the sex out, to stave off their orgasms for as long as sanity allows. But right now, he can't. His mind is set on one goal, and he runs, ceaselessly, toward it. His thighs burns from the exertion of fucking himself on Phainon's cock--he ignores the discomfort.

Nothing in the world matters now but the union of his and Phainon's bodies. Okhema itself could be burning down, and he wouldn't care.

"I-I'm... going to..." Phainon stutters, almost unintelligible. If Mydei had the mind for it, he'd edge him. He doesn't, so he instead increases his pace once again.

"Going to what? Use... *ngh*... your words."

No words are needed, Mydei can feel his knot beginning to swell inside of him. He rarely knots outside of his rut, but it seems he's aroused enough for it this time.

Fuck, this man is going to be the death of him.

"You're so beautiful, g-gods."

"That doesn't... answer my question--"

Phainon comes suddenly, crying out, hands reaching blindly for something to hold onto--he finds Mydei's hips and holds him down on his cock. Mydei bears down on it as much as he can. His knot is so large it almost feels as if his cunt cannot take it--almost.

So full, so warm, so *right*--Mydei only has to rub over his clit with two fingers and he's coming too, seizing, gasping, trembling atop Phainon's twitching cock. He sees stars against the back of his eyelids. His thighs tighten, his hips cant forward--Phainon wails.

"Mydei, oh gods, Mydei," he babbles, chest heaving, still holding him with an iron grip. Even if he let go, they couldn't part, not with his knot still popped. It is a heat searing into Mydei's core, locking them together.

He isn't sure how long it takes before it goes down, and he finally pulls himself off of Phainon. Seed and slick drip from his cunt, dirtying the silken sheets beneath them.

"... Did I satisfy you?" Phainon asks in a shaky voice. His eyes are half-lidded, and his grin is tired.

"Hmm. Not yet, another round might do it. But allow me to lock the doors first."

Phainon can only manage to come one more time before his cock is completely spent. After that, he lavishes Mydei with his mouth and hands, granting him orgasm after orgasm. Some are quick, hurried with impatience, momentary spasms before he insists on continuing. Others roll

over him slowly, blanketing him, until he's writhing against the sheet, a complete mess. Phainon is thorough in his work, as always.

Finally, he has been satisfied, in both body and mind. He has nothing left to give, neither of them do. Completely spent, they lay together in bed, naked bodies intertwined.

It is as pleasant of a reunion as he could have hoped for.

"I've heard pregnant omegas were insatiable, but I didn't think it could be like this," Phainon says, breathless.

The heavy blinds have now been drawn to create an approximation of night, and in the dim glow cast by the nightstand lamp, he looks ethereal. Mydei tries to engrain the sight into his mind.

"You seem to forget who you're dealing with."

"I guess I should've anticipated..." he starts to speak, but is cut off by a yawn. "Gods, you tired me out. I think this is gonna have to wait until morning..."

"Get some rest, you need to recover your strength."

"G'night, then..." Another yawn, and then, he is silent.

It's quiet for a long while. Mydei shuts his eyes, waiting for sleep to come to him, but it doesn't. His mind is still racing.

Now that the whims of his heart have been satisfied, he has nothing left to do but face his destiny.

Damnit, how cruel can the Fates be? There are a thousand things he wishes to do with Phainon, and so many words he wishes to speak. His heart is not satisfied, no, it will never be satisfied. He cannot imagine leaving now, or ever.

"I don't know if we'll be able to mate," he says into the darkness, without thinking.

"What?" Phainon asks, voice thick and somewhat slurred.

"... It's nothing. Go back to sleep."

But Phainon is already sitting up to look at him, brought back from the edge of unconsciousness. "No, I want to know what you mean. Why can't we?"

"Any bite you leave on my skin will certainly fade in seconds."

"Oh. I guess that's true... It's alright, though. We don't need to be mates."

You don't understand, I wish to carry as much memory of you as possible when I must leave, he thinks, but does not say.

"It doesn't bother you?" he asks instead.

"I mean, it bothers the alpha part of my brain that wishes to claim you, but I've never paid much attention to it in the past, so I won't start now. I'm happy to have you no matter what."

"... I love you."

Phainon chokes, and his entire face flushes. "You--... I..."

"You said it to me, is it not acceptable to return your affection?"

"No, it's fine, I just... It kinda came out of nowhere. But I'm happy to hear it returned, of course. I love you too."

Mydei closes his eyes, unable to look at his beaming face any longer. It hurts too badly.

I love you, and I am sorry.

In the morning, he wakes before Phainon, and silently slips out of the room.

If he doesn't claim the Coreflame now, he may just lose his resolve.

"I thought I'd find you here."

For the past hour, Mydei has stood alone in the Vortex of Gensis, staring into the basin, unmoving.

He was going to undergo the trial immediately but found himself waiting for something. No amount of begging himself to proceed could get his mouth to move, and utter the words to beckon Nikador's gaze. He just *couldn't*, not yet.

He has one last thing to say to the person he trusts most in this world.

"I said I would reclaim the Coreflame soon, Deliverer. Don't take too much pride in your thinking."

"I didn't think I'd make it in time, actually. Why did you wait for me?"

"Because I have something to tell you. We both know that the power of strife is a dangerous one, and it may just consume me. So, listen well: if there comes a day when we meet again on the battlefield, and I stand opposed to the Flamechase... Remember to stab your greatsword into my back, through my tenth thoracic vertebra. That is my weak spot, and the only way to kill me.

"Do not hesitate. Whether I still carry our child within me at that point or not... Kill me. There are fates much worse than death in this world."

He has never laid himself bare like this before--not a single other soul knows of his weakness. He hopes Phainon understands the weight of his confession.

"... I will honor your last wish," he affirms, and almost manages to conceal the trembling of his voice. Mydei does not mention it. He knows this is painful, there is no need to add to his suffering.

"I'm ready to ascend now, Phainon. You should go. The outsider Stelle returned from the Grove of Epiphany and says there is a great foe to be vanquished."

His voice shakes too, and he curses himself. He never imagined his last moments of mortality would be so terrible. It feels as if a beast has clawed open his chest and is ripping out his heart piece by piece.

Oh, how badly he wishes to turn around and look at Phainon with these mortal eyes, to see that face one more time before he is irreversibly changed. But he knows if he does, he will break.

"Before I came here, Aglaea briefed me on the details. That great foe... they are the swordsman that destroyed my home. I plan to enact my revenge."

"Just don't act in haste. It is all too easy to be consumed by hatred, and lose everything. I would hate to see you die for nothing."

"I won't be alone in my fight."

It is a statement, but also a request. Mydei hopes he will be able to honor it.

"Indeed you will not. Farewell... my love."

"Farewell, my love."

Divinity does not feel as Mydei anticipated.

He expected it to consume him, to burn his self to ash and rebirth him anew, just as Nikador taunted. As they clashed once more, they did not stop provoking him with his worst fear. The battlefield reflected it; he saw an unending sea of shin-deep blood that dragged at his feet, a thousand arms reaching up in desperation, begging for his help. The deaths of his comrades played out before him, a maddening loop of grief and sickness. Again and again, they reminded him of his father, of his banishment, of the hatred that would certainly become his own.

And yet, he did not falter. When he finally overpowered them, he did not hesitate to rip their head straight from their shoulders, spilling their ichor upon a pile of defeated corpses.

"*Fine work, Mydeimos. Thou art worthy of my blessing. Reclaim my Coreflame, and cleanse this world of filth."*

Madness, violence, overwhelming rage--he prepared himself to buckle under the weight of his god's blood-soaked past. A mortal soul is not meant to endure it, he was certain it would drive him to instant insanity.

It does burn, horribly. Pure agony shoots through him, overloading every single nerve in a sudden, blinding flash. He thinks he screams, but it's impossible to tell. There is no sensation left but pain. The Coreflame bullies its way into his mortal flesh that desperately tries to reject it. This is not meant for him, no human was meant to accept the power of a god.

But he endures, and it does not destroy him. The pain fades, and it is replaced with something indescribable. It flows alongside his blood, intermixes with every muscle and vessel and fiber of his body, settles deep into the marrow of his bones. What was initially rejected is now welcomed openly.

It settles as a controlled fire, smoldering within his chest but not overpowering. In some ways, it is pleasant. It feels like coming home.

A strength like no other is now at his behest. The slightest twitch of his fingers--he feels it, solid and certain, an undeniable weight that now obeys him.

If anything in his mind has changed, it is simply the clarity of his thoughts. That, and the final words of his prophecy, forever etched into his psyche.

One day, you shall die with a wound in your back.

How simple are those words, and how heavy.

He does not have the time to consider them, not yet. When the dust is settled, there will be time enough for contemplation. There are much more pressing matters that demand his attention.

First, he presses his hand against his abdomen. He can feel the soul of the child now; it is like a candle's flame, tiny yet determined. He isn't sure if his divinity will transfer to them, but it's no real concern.

"Good," he says to himself, content in their safety. Now, there is a request he must honor, and thankfully, he still has the mind to do so.

A hundred miles away is Castrum Kremnos--it only takes him an instant to warp there, and land directly beneath the point of the Lance of Fury. A wave of crystallized blood heralds his arrival, spiking up from the ground without his input. There is no need, not anymore. Such actions are trivialities.

"You didn't come down from the sky?"

Mydei bows his head to hide his smile as he marches forward. The ring of his footsteps in the arena commands attention. For a moment, the world is quiet, listening.

"I may enter however I please, Deliverer. This is my city."

With a sharp flick of his wrist, the Flame Reaver is impaled against the nearby wall, countless shards of blood holding their body in place. A maneuver that would've taken all of his focus mere hours ago is now as easily as breathing. He can feel the strength of this enemy as they work to free themself from his attack; were it not for his divinity, he certainly would not be able to best them.

Now, however, he knows it will be a simple fight.

"Shall we vanquish this foe together, king of Kremnos?

"We shall."

As the Flame Reaver leaps towards them, he and Phainon fall into step alongside each other, knocking back each attack with practiced ease. They are a well-oiled machine, working together as if they are two halves of a whole, meant for this one task. Phainon feints--Mydei makes the strike.

Mydei parries--Phainon lunges. Each time one is occupied, the other steps in to protect their weakness. They suddenly have the Flame Reaver on the defensive, folding beneath the dual onslaught.

After all, he and Phainon were always meant for this. It is the battlefield where passion is kindled and fed, and it is where their romance first began.

Mydei can only hope that this is not the last time they stand together against a foe.

When the Flame Reaver summon apparitions to attempt to regain their advantage, Mydei doesn't even flinch. He throws his arms out, crystals surging forward to meet them, shredding their ghostly forms before they can even try to attack. Phainon handles the others, dispatching them in clean, swift cuts. His brutality is controlled, a complete contrast to his own technique.

Mydei has always respected it. In all of their duels, Phainon has exemplified a level of precision that he himself could never reach. His performance now is a sight to behold; if Mydei ever had doubts over his role as Deliverer, this would summarily banish them.

Strikes land, metal meets metal, and crystals of blood blossom around them. The air is hot, almost electric with the thrill of battle. Mydei laughs aloud as he charges forward, knocking back each new apparition that appears. His target is in sight: the exposed chest of the Flame Reaver.

They manage to dodge, just barely, and a counterattack follows. Their blade arcs, nearly clipping Mydei in the flank; he sidesteps, but is caught off guard by their next follow-up slamming into his chest. He falls into a roll and quickly settles into a crouch, glancing around for an opponent that has vanished--

"Mydei, watch out!"

Behind him, he feels the air shift. How pathetic, it seems the Flame Reaver is going for a backstab. Phainon has blocked the strike before he's turned around, and beats their blade with enough force to send them flying.

Mydei doesn't need to say anything, he simply smiles, and Phainon does too. Time pauses for a moment as they meet each others' gazes. Gods, how perfect are Phainon's eyes, shining with excitement and adrenaline.

My heart will always belong to you.

And then, the moment ends. Mydei pushes off the ground, soaring forward to redouble the attack, knocking their opponent into the ground with such force that the stone ruptures. Still, they are able to dart away at the last second, Phainon's downswing missing by a hair's breadth.

"I tire of this opponent," Mydei scoffs, "may I end them?"

"Go right ahead."

It requires as much effort as brushing off a stray bug to launch the Flame Reaver a hundred feet into the air, out of the mouth of the arena. The metal on his gauntlets are dented from the force--no matter. Mydei follows them up without pause.

His fist draws back, and something within him lurches, surging to meet the tension cording in his arm, pure and hot. He invites it.

Here it is, finally: the source of his divinity. Countless warriors have perished under the Lance of Fury, and now, they rally with him. Mydei is strife itself, an army within one body, a vessel for perfect destruction.

His strike lands, cracking bone. The Flame Reaver is in front of him, and then they are a thousand feet away, lodged into the side of a spire. Red crystals bloom around them, ensnaring them completely, no matter desperately how they struggle. A gesture of his finger, and the crystals grow, piercing their flesh.

"Heroic souls of strife, heed my call! I am Mydeimos, kingslayer, godslayer, last king of Kremnos! I command you: vanquish this foul agent of death!"

And the Lance of Fury, once wielded by Nikador, crystallizes in his hands.

Against his palms. it burns as hot as plasma. A mortal soul would surely vaporize in its presence. The air around him crackles, searing his lungs with each slow inhale. It is unfathomable, the weight of what he wields.

All the kings of Kremnos dreamed of this power, and now, it is his. This is his first action as the new demigod of Strife, and it will etch him solidly into the annals of history. All will know the name Mydeimos, final bearer of the bloodied crown.

With his mind clear for the first time in his life, he knows exactly what he must do.

"Die!"

The lance finds its mark, and it is over.

The air ionizes from the heat of the explosion,
searing Mydei's eyes and casting a glow so bright it is as if the sun has risen above Castrum Kremnos once more. He does not blink. The light bathes him, welcomes him. There is nothing to shy away from.

The wind gusts by next, carrying with it of the pulverized crystals shattered by the impact. It collects around his feet in drifts, sparkling in the afterglow. He reaches down and grabs a handful. The soft grains fall through the net of his fingers, scattering into nothing.

Finally, it is over.

His greatest fear has been dispelled, and he shall stride forth into the future.

In Okhema, the sun beats down as unrelentingly as ever, and the citizens proceed with their daily lives, unbothered by the uncertainty of the future.

Here, in Phainon's home, away from the busiest streets, all that can be heard is the distant melody of a lyre from some nearby performer. The peaceful quiet envelopes them, unbroken.

"Phainon, it is time for me to leave."

After hours of thought, Mydei has finally settled on what to say. Perhaps there isn't much to say that Phainon hasn't already realized himself, but he's owed something, at least.

Mydei hoped that divinity would gift him the knowledge of how to do this with as little pain as possible. It has not. For all the clarity he has been gifted, there are still plentiful unknowns.

"You only just got to my house, do you have to go so soon?"

They're sitting at the dining table, empty boxes that once held a collection of pastries now populated only by crumbs. Mydei isn't sure if he needs to eat anymore--he has much to learn about his new body--but he wanted something sweet, and Phainon went along with him to the bakery.

They've spent the last few days doing menial things like that. Mydei has tried his best to savor every moment, to stretch out the hours left with he man he loves so dearly, but he knows he cannot linger any longer.

A new battlefield awaits him, and he will fight alone.

"That's not what I mean. It's time for me to leave Okhema."

"Oh. You're going home now, aren't you?"

"Yes. I do not believe I'll be returning to Okhema ever again. So, I believe it is best if we end things."

It is the worst sentence he has ever had to utter. He had to practice saying it a hundred times just to be able to manage it with an even tone.

Oh, how he despises himself for it. It is so, so cruel. Phainon offered up his heart and Mydei is crushing that idyllic dream of love in the span of a breath.

But it's for the best.

If he tells Phainon he no longer loves him, then he'll be free to continue his life without the burden of Mydei's absence haunting him. Painfully but quickly--that is how wounds are treated on the battlefield, and it is how Mydei will do this.

When he receives no response, Mydei stands, and takes the first few steps to the door.

"End things... between us?"

Phainon has risen to his feet, as if to follow him, but he's frozen in place. He seems entirely lost, all his usual confidence melting away into shock.

"Yes."

The pure, agonizing anguish that overtakes his features yanks the air right from Mydei's chest.

Godsdamnit, this is impossible.

"The Coreflame has changed me. I am no longer the person you fell in love with. You shouldn't waste your energy on me, it will only agonize you. The affection I feel for you is rapidly fading. Soon, I will feel nothing at all."

He hopes it will be enough. He needs it to be enough, so Phainon can forget him.

"... Has anybody ever told you that you're a terrible liar?"

Of course, Phainon has always been able to read him with ease.

"I'm simply trying to make this easier for you."

"You don't need to. I'll be okay, I will. If you really want to end things, that's alright, but... Be honest with me, please. All I want is the truth."

"I just thought... By the hells, I don't know. I thought it was for the best. Isn't this worse? To know what I have become, and what I must do, but love me regardless?"

"Even if loving you is the hardest thing in the world, I'll do it without hesitation, Mydei."

"But will you be able to handle my absence? I do not believe that I will return to Okhema ever again, as I said."

"Wait, you... you're serious about leaving?"

"I must fend off the Black Tide now that Nikador is dead. It is my new duty."

Phainon crumples. His entire body seems to slacken, as if all his energy has been suddenly sucked out. His knees buckle; he grabs Mydei's drape, claws at his shoulders for purchase, leaves deep red marks in his skin in his desperation. Mydei reaches down to catch him before he can hit the ground.

"Please don't go, *please* don't leave me too," he chokes, between sobs and hitching breaths. "I can't lose you, *please."*

"Phainon, I..."

"I need you, Mydei, I can't--I can't *do* this, I'm sorry, please stay. I'll do anything, I'll be better, I'll be whatever you want me to be, just don't go."

Mydei does not know what to say anymore, so instead, he lowers them both to the tile floor, slowly, and holds him close.

His breathing gets more erratic, and he begins to curl up on himself. "I know I'm being selfish, I'm sorry, I'm ruining everything, I'm sorry--"

"You can cry, do not be ashamed."

He does, for a long, long time. He seems to lose control of himself--his fingers lock around anything they can find, squeezing, tangling in Mydei's hair, almost pulling, but the sting is bearable. That is not the difficult part, no. The sounds he makes are so dreadful, and Mydei feels his heart cracking into pieces, because he is still human in the ways that matter the most.

Being stabbed in his back would not hurt as badly as this, he thinks. To hold Phainon as he bitterly weeps, wracked by sobs so powerful that they jerk his entire frame, knowing that he is the cause of his anguish--this is some sort of nightmare he wouldn't dare to imagine otherwise.

It feels so *wrong.* He despises it all. Damn the Fates for choosing this path for him. Why must he suffer like this? Why must Phainon endure more than he already has?

Mydei wants to offer some comfort, *anything* to make Phainon happy again, but even if he knew what to say, there is a tightness in the back of throat that he knows will turn into tears. All he can do is hold him in silence.

Eventually, Phainon's sobs quiet down to hiccups and sniffles, he extracts himself from their embrace, enough to cradle the swell of Mydei's midsection. His expression is fractured. His eyes are bloodshot and red-rimmed, his lips are quivering, and tear tracks stain his cheeks.

"I only just learned of them, and now... now I have to say goodbye. Gods... Will you send me pictures of them when they are born, at least?"

"... I will not allow you to miss their birth. A kinder world awaits us, our reunion will not be too late. You will be a part of their life, I am certain."

It is terribly naive to make such a declaration, but Mydei wants it to be true with such fervor, and he cannot consider the other possibilities, not right now.

"Can I come visit, then?"

"I don't know," he says carefully. "It isn't safe in Castrum Kremnos--it won't be for many months to come. But if there comes a day when I have beaten back the Black Tide enough to afford me some freedom, then I shall call for you."

"And you'll message me with your teleslate?"

"Whenever I am able."

Phainon lets out a shaky breath. "Okay, that's... okay."

Mydei kisses him softly, tasting the salt of his tears on his lips. They linger like that for ages, in the warmth of their embrace, Phainon's hands still resting over his womb.

"... I must leave," Mydei whispers, when he can bear it no longer.

"I know. Damnit, I know. Can I give you one last thing, at least?"

"Of course."

Phainon digs into his pocket and produces a small golden ring. It is polished to a beautiful luster, and brilliantly reflects the light shining through the open window. He picks up Mydei's right hand, bare of its gauntlet, and carefully slides it onto his ring finger.

On its face is a carved symbol that Mydei would recognize in a heartbeat. He stares at it for what feels like an eternity, completely stunned.

"This is my mother's signet ring. How...?"

"It took a very long time to find... I've spent the last year searching, I think. Chartonus helped a lot, and he helped me fix it when we finally fished it up. I really only did the last round of polishing."

"I see," Mydei forces out. "This is... It means a lot to me. I shall wear it with pride. Thank you."

"I'm glad I could find it."

Slowly, painfully, Mydei stands. "Does that settle everything?"

"I guess it does, huh."

"... Farewell, my love."

"Farewell, my love."

Mydei walks out the door, and does not look back. His eyes remain trained at the horizon as he passes the city gates, marches away from the safety of Kephale's light, crosses the endless darkness of the Evernight, parting the sea of enemies with mindless ease.

It is only once he has reached his new throne, built from mighty crystals of his own power, that he turns back to face the world behind him.

The son of Gorgo will be crowned in blood.

"Mother, I'm home."

Chapter End Notes

phainon is not gonna survive long distance. rip to my king.

i transferred all of my sadness over the 3.1 quest into this fic so now i dont have to deal with it anymore. at least the mydei stuff, i cut out trianne's death because uh i cannot even process that. this fic is sad enough as is.

i fucking hate sad endings man. i'll take all the angst in the world i just want it to resolve in the end. so in that vein, whenever the amphoreus story is complete or once i feel like i have enough context, i'll write an epilogue!! and it will be happy even if the actual canon is tragic, i dont give a shit!! ~~also because i want an excuse to write more pregnant mydei smut~~

ahem anyway. let me pull myself together. for now that's all, goodbye and thank you so much for reading!!

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